

Raising Believers

*Christian Parenting and the Costly Work of Forming Faith
in a Post-Christian World*

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Raising Believers

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INTRODUCTION

The Faith You Cannot Transmit

I have five sons. I have been a pastor long enough to have baptized children I once held as infants. And I have sat in two kinds of living rooms. In the first, parents in their sixties whose grown children no longer claim the faith. In the second, parents in their thirties, terrified their children will end up in the first room. Something has broken in the way Christian households form children, and no curriculum is going to fix it.

This is a book for parents who already sense that. They have done the bedtime devotionals and the Sunday school drop-offs and the youth group volunteering, and they still carry a quiet suspicion that something is not taking root. They did what they were told to do. And they are watching children they love lose interest, or harden, or disappear into a phone that catechizes them in a different gospel every seven seconds.

Let me be plain about what this book is not. It is not a

What this book argues is slower and more uncomfortable. Faith forms in children the way it forms in anyone. Through the weight of a life lived near other lives that actually believe. Through the presence of adults who are not pretending. Through questions answered rather than deflected. Through a household whose ordinary rhythms say, over years, that God is real and that following Him is the most serious thing we do.

That kind of formation cannot be outsourced. It cannot be scheduled into thirty-minute devotions everyone dreads. It cannot be purchased in a curriculum. It cannot be handed to the youth pastor, God bless the youth pastor. Faith forms in the soil of a home. If the soil is thin, nothing grows, no matter how good the seeds are.

THE KITCHEN WHERE THIS BEGAN

Here is the part I have to say up front, because it is the part that keeps me honest. I am inside this indictment. I have been, in different seasons, the distracted father, the anxious father, the father who outsourced what he should have carried, the father who answered too quickly because he could not admit he did not know. I have performed spirituality in front of my sons when what they needed was a father who was actually praying. I have told them the

This book did not start in a study. It started in my kitchen, about six years ago, when one of my older boys looked at me during a family devotional and said, Dad, do you actually want to be doing this right now. He was not being disrespectful. He was being observant. He had watched me check my phone twice during the reading. He had watched my eyes glaze over my own questions. He had watched me rush the prayer because I still had emails to answer. He was not questioning the faith. He was questioning me. He was asking whether the thing we were doing mattered to the person who said it mattered.

I wish I could tell you I handled it well. I gave a defensive little speech about the importance of family devotions. He did not respond. He did not need to. His point settled into me over the following weeks like a stone dropping through water. He was right. The devotional had become a performance. I was checking a box, and my sons could see it, and they were drawing the correct conclusion: that this faith was important enough to perform but not important enough to be real. That evening began the slow dismantling of the model I had been running. Not the model I preached. The model I lived. They were not the same model, and my sons knew the difference even when I did not.

So I want to be careful about the diagnosis. It is not that Christian parents are failing their children. It is that Christian parents were sold a model of formation that was never going to work, and many of them have run that

THE VIEW FROM THE PASTOR'S CHAIR

The view from this chair is different from the view from the pew. I watch families doing everything right by every metric the evangelical world has handed them. Regular attendance. Small group. Missions giving. Bible memory. And I watch their children leave. Not at the margins. At the center. The most committed families in my church are sometimes the ones whose children walk away with the most resolve, because those children got the full version of the model and found it wanting.

I also watch families nobody would put on a poster. Families that are messy, that miss Sundays, that have never finished a single study. And their kids are walking with Jesus in their twenties and thirties. When you ask those kids why, they say the same thing. My parents were real. They were not impressive. They were real. The faith in our house was not a program. It was the way my mom and dad actually lived.

That observation, repeated across twenty years of ministry, is where this book comes from. Not a theory. A pattern, consistent enough that I am willing to call it a principle: faith forms in proximity to a real life, not in exposure to a right program. The implications are uncomfortable for a generation of parents who invested heavily in programs and lightly in their own interior lives.

Some of you came to this book because of the statistics. The numbers shift depending on who counts and how they

The common evangelical response has been to build better programs. Better youth ministries. Better apologetics. Better college transition strategies. Better worship designed to keep young people engaged. None of these is wrong in itself. All of them miss the point. The programs were not bad. The programs were being asked to do what only a household can do, while the households behind the program attendance were teaching a different catechism than the one the programs taught.

This is not a comfortable diagnosis. It is the one I believe is true, and I have staked the book on it. If I am wrong, the rest of it falls apart. If I am right, then the most important decision a Christian parent makes is not which church to attend or which school to choose or which curriculum to follow. The most important decision is what kind of person the parent is going to be, in their own home, when no one from the church is watching.

THE FORTRESS AND THE PRESENCE

The old model runs roughly like this. Christian formation is primarily cognitive. Get the child to believe the right things, so teach the content. Sunday school, Awana, VBS, youth group, Christian school if you can manage it. Stack the content. Then build behavioral

I call this the fortress model. You build the walls, fill the interior with the right content, patrol the perimeter, keep the bad out and the good in. And when you release the child, you hope the fortress held long enough that they will carry the architecture out on their own. The problem is threefold.

First, the fortress is permeable. It always was. In 1985, the fortress had cracks. In 2026, it has a smartphone-sized hole in the wall that connects to every idea, image, and ideology our species has ever produced. The wall cannot hold. It was only ever built to hold until the next Sunday, and even that is optimistic now.

Second, the fortress produces a child who knows what is inside the walls and what is outside them but who has never been taught to think. The right answers were inside the fortress, so the child knows them. The wrong answers were outside, so the child has never been allowed to engage them. When the wrong answers finally arrive, at college, at work, online, the child has no structure for processing them. They were protected from the questions and never equipped to handle them. And the questions, when they come, do not feel like an attack on the faith. They feel like the first honest conversation the child has ever had about whether any of this is true.

Third, and worst, the fortress treats the child as a container to be filled rather than a person to be formed. Good content in, bad content out. The child's own curiosity, doubt, desire, and interior life are not part of the

I have a different model to offer. It is not new. It is very old. It is the way faith was actually passed down for most of Christian history, before the programmatic era, before age-graded infrastructure, before we assumed formation was something you do to a child rather than something that happens near one. The model is presence. Formed presence, over time, in ordinary rooms.

It works like this. A parent who is being formed by Christ, who is honest about that, who has a real interior life with God, who lets that life show in ordinary moments, who answers hard questions instead of deflecting, who lets their failures be visible and their repentance be real, who treats the faith not as a performance for the children but as the animating reality of the house, that parent is the primary formation environment. Not the curriculum. Not the church. Not the school. The parent.

This does not mean the parent must be impressive. It means the parent must be real. A parent whose faith is small but honest does more for formation than a parent whose faith is large but performed. Children do not need a parent who has all the answers. They need a parent whose life makes the questions worth asking.

The old model has many problems, and the chapters ahead work through them in order. It treats faith as a

All of that is in the pages that follow. But underneath every chapter, hold this one sentence in front of you, because everything turns on it.

*You cannot give your children a faith
you do not have.*

If your own faith is thin, if it runs on performance, if it has shrunk to attendance and correct opinions, if you have not wrestled with God in a long time, if you have stopped

I learned this the hard way, not from a book but from watching my own children absorb not what I said but what I was. They did not absorb my sermons. They absorbed my Monday mornings. They did not absorb my theology of prayer. They absorbed whether I actually prayed when no one was performing. They did not absorb my lectures about Scripture. They absorbed whether the Bible on my nightstand had been opened that week or whether it was furniture.

Children are the most honest theologians in the house. They evaluate the adults every day, and they are not evaluating what the adults say. They are evaluating the gap between what the adults say and what the adults are. When the gap is small, faith forms. When the gap is wide, something else forms. Something that looks like faith on the outside and is hollow inside. Something that holds until the child is old enough to name what they have been watching.

This is the hope and it is also the cost. The hope is that the most important thing you can do for your children's faith is attend to your own. You do not need a better curriculum. You need a deeper life. The cost is that there is no shortcut. You cannot outsource this. You cannot catch up at fourteen after twelve years of practical absence. The work begins in the parent's interior life, works outward through the texture of a home, and compounds quietly over years.

I want to say a word to the parents who need this book most, because they are the ones most likely to feel disqualified by it. You have already failed. I do not mean that as a judgment. I mean it as a fact. You have already said the wrong thing at the wrong moment. You have already lost your temper when your child needed your steadiness. You have already chosen the screen over the conversation, the schedule over the person, the shortcut over the investment. You have failed. So have I. The question is not whether you have failed. The question is whether the failure is the last word.

It is not. And the reason has nothing to do with your competence. It has to do with the grace of a God who has been forming people through imperfect parents since the garden. Abraham lied. Isaac played favorites. Jacob manipulated. Moses lost his temper. David was absent from his sons in the years that mattered most. And God kept forming a people through every one of them. Not because they were adequate. Because He was. That does not excuse negligence. It does mean the door to faithful parenting is not locked to people who have already blown it. It has always been open. And the key is not perfection. The key is presence. Imperfect, honest, repentant, faithful presence over years.

I once counseled a father in his late fifties who had spent his career building a business and his evenings in front of the television. His children were raised in church but had never seen their father pray outside a meal. They had never heard him say what God meant to him. They had never watched him open a Bible that was not in a pew

He asked me what he could do, and I told him three things. Become the man you wish you had been, not as a strategy to win her back but as obedience to the God who is still forming you. Tell her the truth: that your faith was real but you hid it, and hiding it was wrong. And pray for her every single day, by name, and do not stop. He did all three. His daughter has not returned to the faith as I write this. But the father is a different man, and the door has been open for three years now, and the daughter knows it is open, because the father has become the kind of man who keeps it open.

This book is for that father as much as for the mother of a toddler. The principles in these chapters are not age-locked. They work in the home with a newborn and in the conversation with a thirty-year-old, because formation is not a program that expires. It is a way of being that God can use at any point in the story. It is for the parent of young children who wants to start well, and the parent of teenagers who feels like they are starting over. It is for the single mother who is doing this alone and has been told, usually by implication, that her household is incomplete. It is not. It is for the father present in body and absent in spirit who is ready to change. It is for the grandparent given a second chance at formation, the stepparent forming faith in children they did not raise from birth, the

One last thing I have to be honest about. This book is not a guarantee. I cannot promise that if you follow every principle in these pages your children will walk with Jesus into adulthood. I know families who did everything right, or close to it, and their children walked away. I know families who did almost nothing deliberate and their children are among the most faithful believers I have met. The sovereignty of God is real, and it means the outcome is not entirely in your hands. What is in your hands is the soil.

You can tend the soil. You can pull the weeds. You can water the ground. Whether the seed sprouts and grows to its full height is between the seed and the God who made it. That should be both humbling and liberating. Humbling, because you cannot guarantee the result. Liberating, because you do not have to. Your job is faithfulness. The harvest is God's. The best thing you can do for that harvest is to become the kind of soil where faith has its best chance of taking root.

So turn the page if you would rather have the truth than the comfortable lie that you can give your children what you have not let God give you. This book does not end in a neat resolution. It cannot. The work of raising believing children does not resolve. It continues, past their childhood, past their leaving home, past your ability to control any outcome, into the years when your only tools are prayer and presence and the open door. I will prepare

CHAPTER ONE

What We Mean When We Say Formation

There is a word we throw around in Christian parenting circles, and most of the time we are using it to mean something it does not mean. The word is formation. We make it a dressed-up synonym for teaching, or for discipline, or for the whole package of Sunday school and family devotions and good habits. But formation is older and stranger than any of that. If we are going to raise children in the faith, we have to recover what it actually is.

Formation is what happens to a human being who spends years near a particular kind of presence. It is slower than teaching and deeper than behavior. It does not produce outputs on a predictable timeline. You cannot measure it in a catechism quiz. You recognize it later, when you notice that a person thinks a certain way, responds a certain way, carries a certain weight, and you realize they did not get that from any single lesson. They got it from a life lived near other lives, over years, in a

Most Christian parents are running an education strategy and calling it formation. The strategy goes like this. Get the right content into the child. Protect the child from the wrong content. Structure enough repetition to make the content stick. Hope the content becomes conviction. That is education. It is not formation. It can be part of formation, but it is never the whole of it, and when it is treated as the whole, it produces children who know the right answers and have no interior connection to the God those answers describe.

Somewhere in the second half of the twentieth century, American evangelicalism made a decisive turn toward information as the primary vehicle of spiritual growth. There were reasons. The fundamentalist-modernist controversy of the early 1900s had produced a Christianity suspicious of experience, suspicious of mystery, suspicious of anything that could not be printed on a doctrinal statement. The way you knew someone was Christian was that they believed the right propositions. The way you formed a Christian child was that you got the right propositions into them early enough and often enough that they stuck.

This was not entirely wrong. Doctrine matters. Content matters. A child who grows up with no biblical knowledge is not formed in the faith. But the emphasis on information did something its advocates did not intend. It reduced the Christian life to a set of ideas to be believed rather than a way of being to be inhabited. And once the Christian life is a set of ideas, you can deliver it through programs, because programs are how you deliver ideas. You can age-grade it. You can put it in a workbook. You can

Formation did not follow. Not because the information was wrong. Because information is not formation.

I grew up without a father. I did not grow up Christian. I came to faith in college, through a roommate who did not lecture me and a visitor to our apartment who answered my actual questions rather than the questions he wished I were asking. What shaped my early faith was not a curriculum. It was being near people who were believing in a way I had not encountered before. I watched how they handled disappointment. I watched how they treated women. I watched how they talked about money. I watched how they prayed when they thought I was not listening. That was formation. The content came later. The formation came first.

THE CATECHUMENATE

The early church understood this. Before there were catechism books, before there were Sunday school curricula, before there were children's Bibles with cartoon illustrations, there was the catechumenate. The catechumenate was the process by which a person was formed into the faith over one to three years. It included instruction. But the instruction was embedded in a life. The catechumen lived among believers. They watched believers pray. They watched believers fast. They watched believers serve the poor. They watched believers suffer. They watched believers die well. The formation happened

When Paul wrote to Timothy, he did not say, I taught you the right content and therefore you are formed. He wrote something else:

You have followed my teaching, my conduct, my aim in life, my faith, my patience, my love, my steadfastness, my persecutions and sufferings.

— 2 TIMOTHY 3:10-11

That is a formation inventory. Teaching is first on the list. But the list does not stop there. It includes conduct, aim, faith, patience, love, steadfastness. It includes suffering. Timothy was formed by proximity to a life. The teaching was part of the formation. It was not the formation itself.

Now consider how most Christian households operate. The parents have the content. The Bibles, the podcasts, the sermons, the small group material. The children are exposed to the content. But the children are not forming near believing parents so much as near parents who attend Christian events. There is a difference. A parent can be in Christian spaces every week and have no formed interior life. A child raised near that parent receives the externals without the center, and the externals without the center is precisely the recipe for what we used to call pharisaism and now call church culture.

I have watched this play out for twenty years in pastoral ministry. The families where the children's faith has gone the distance are not the families that attended the most programs. They are the families where the parents had an actual life with God that was visible in ordinary moments.

PROXIMITY TO A LIFE

Formation is not something you do to a child. It is something that happens in proximity. Proximity to what. Proximity to a life that is actually being lived under the lordship of Christ. Your kitchen is a formation space. Your car on the way to school is a formation space. The way you treat your spouse at seven fifteen in the morning is a formation space. The way you respond to the email from your boss that you did not want to receive is a formation space. Your child is reading all of it. The child reads what you actually are, not what you say you are, because the child has been watching you long enough to know the difference.

That is why formation is terrifying. You cannot fake it over the timeline a child has with you. You can fake it on Sunday morning in front of people who see you two hours a week. You cannot fake it in front of a seven-year-old who has watched you for two thousand five hundred days. The child knows. The child knows whether prayer in your home is a ritual that adults perform for the child's benefit or whether the adults in this house actually pray. The child knows whether the Bible is a reference book that gets pulled out for arguments or a book the parent is being

*A parent whose faith is small but
honest does more for formation than a
parent whose faith is extensive but
performative.*

This does not mean your interior life has to be impressive. It means it has to be real. The child is not impressed by theological vocabulary. The child is watching for alignment. When the words the parent says about God line up with the way the parent is actually living, something forms. When they do not line up, something also forms, and it is the thing we are all grieving in the generation leaving the church right now. They did not leave because the teaching was too demanding. They left because the teaching and the life did not match, and they noticed.

Formation is happening at all times, in all directions. You are not choosing whether to form your children. You are choosing in which direction. A home that runs on anxiety is forming anxious children. A home that runs on performance is forming performers. A home that runs on conflict avoidance is forming people who will not name truth when it costs them. A home that runs on consumption is forming consumers. None of those parents

THE FORMATION OF THE PARENT

This is why the formation of a child begins with the formation of the parent. I will say it a dozen times in this book because it cannot be said too often. The parent's own walk with Christ is not a private devotional matter. It is the soil in which the child's faith will grow or will not. A parent being sanctified, slowly, honestly, visibly, creates a different household than a parent performing sanctification. The child does not know the word sanctification. The child knows whether the parent is changing.

Here is the part I have to say because I need to hear it myself. You cannot curriculum your way out of your own lack of life with God. You can buy better books. You can enroll in better schools. You can join better churches. None of that touches the problem if the problem is that your own walk with Jesus has flattened out. Children form around the center of a parent's actual life. If the center is work, they will form around work. If the center is appearance, they will form around appearance. If the center is Christ, they will form around Christ. The center is not what you say it is. It is what your week actually shows.

I have to name a particular failure I have seen in pastors' homes, including my own. Pastors are professionally Christian. Their work is Christ. Their calendar is church. Their social network is believers. It is

The hope in this chapter is small and heavy. It is that formation in your children is doable. Not easy, not quick, not guaranteed. But doable, because the lever is not external to you. It is the thing you already have direct access to, which is your own life before God. You cannot control what your children will choose when they are grown. You can only be the kind of person near whom formation in a Christlike direction is more likely than not. Honest instead of performative, hungry instead of settled, present instead of distracted, slow to anger when the children press on the places your flesh wants to hide. That is what formation is. Proximity to a formed life. Over years. In ordinary rooms. With a thousand small honesties along the way.

WHAT A THOUSAND MORNINGS DO

Because the concept can feel abstract, let me describe two mornings in two different homes. Both Christian. Both

In the first home, the alarm goes off and the household immediately enters management mode. The parent is on the phone before their feet touch the floor. Breakfast is functional. The conversation, such as it is, is about logistics. Who needs to be where. What needs to be signed. The parent is tense because they are late. The children absorb the tension. Nobody prays. Nobody mentions God. The Bible on the counter is under a stack of mail. The parent drops the children at school with a hurried goodbye and drives to work listening to a podcast about productivity. The morning has catechized the children in a theology of urgency. The world is demanding. There is not enough time. The most important thing is efficiency. God is not in the morning. God is somewhere else, for later.

In the second home, the household wakes up at roughly the same speed. The parent is tired. The morning is not serene. There is still cereal to pour and permission slips to find. But somewhere in the first fifteen minutes, the parent pauses. Not for long. For ninety seconds. The parent says, out loud, at the table: Lord, thank you for this day. Be with these boys today. Help me be patient. The children hear it. They do not respond. They are eating cereal. But they hear it. The parent is not performing a devotional. The parent is doing what the parent does every morning, taking thirty seconds to orient the household toward God before the logistics take over. On the drive to school, the parent asks the child about something the child mentioned the night before. Not school. Something personal. The child, surprised at being remembered, opens up for two minutes. The parent listens. The morning has catechized the children in a different theology. God is in the morning.

Neither morning is dramatic. Neither will be remembered by the child as a specific event. But multiply each one by a thousand, and you have two entirely different formation environments. The first produces a child who sees God as an addition to an already full life. The second produces a child who sees God as the orienting reality of the household. Formation is what a thousand mornings do. It is not what one sermon says. It is the accumulated weight of a life lived in a particular direction, and the child, who is in the room for all of it, absorbs the direction even when they are not paying attention.

Parents tell me they do not have time for formation. That life is too busy. That the schedule does not allow for it. I have felt it myself, many times. But the objection misunderstands what formation is. Formation is not an additional activity you add to the schedule. Formation is the character of the activities already in it. It is not thirty minutes of devotions bolted onto an otherwise secular day. It is the way you are present in the day you already have. You are already forming your children every hour they are with you. The only question is in which direction.

I am not saying that teaching does not matter. It does. Content matters. Scripture matters. Doctrine matters. What I am saying is that teaching without formation produces a child who can defend a position they do not actually hold. And formation without teaching produces a child with a warm sense of spirituality and no structure to carry them when the world presses hard. The two belong together. But if I had to choose which comes first, I would say formation. You can add teaching to a formed child

A child raised on formation without content is like a tree that grows strong but does not know its own species. It needs instruction. It needs to learn the name and shape of the thing it already is. When that instruction comes, it confirms what the child already knew in their bones. A child raised on content without formation is like a blueprint without a house. The plans are precise. The specs are correct. But nobody built anything. The child has all the information and no structure to live in. When the wind comes, the blueprint shelters no one. Build the house. Let the blueprint serve the house. Let the formation come first, and let the content fill the space the formation has opened.

THE COMPARISON TRAP AND THE FEAR

There is one thing I see in nearly every conversation I have with Christian parents about formation. The comparison trap. You look at another family and see what appears to be a seamlessly formed household. The children are polite. They quote Scripture. They lead worship at youth group. The parents seem calm. The home seems ordered. Then you look at your own household, where the morning was chaos and the evening ended in tears and the Bible reading lasted four minutes before someone spilled milk on the table, and you think, we are failing.

You are not failing. You are comparing your interior to their exterior. You are comparing your Tuesday morning to their Sunday morning. You are comparing your actual life

I have been inside both kinds of homes. The ones that look formed from the outside and the ones that feel chaotic from the inside. From twenty years of pastoral observation, I can tell you the correlation between external polish and internal formation is weaker than you think. Some of the most polished Christian families I have known produced children who walked away from the faith the moment they left home, because the formation was cosmetic. It was behavior management dressed in spiritual language. And some of the most chaotic, struggling, imperfect households I have known produced children whose faith is as deep as bedrock, because the formation was real. It was messy and inconsistent and often interrupted by spilled milk. But the center held. And the center was not the parents' competence. The center was Christ, actually present, in the middle of the mess.

Stop comparing your home to the home that looks better from the outside. Start asking the questions that matter. Is Christ the center of this household, not in theory but in practice. Do my children see me turn to God when I am afraid. Do my children hear me pray when nothing is wrong. Do my children know that they are loved with a love that is not contingent on their performance. Those are the formation questions, and you can answer them honestly without looking at anyone else's home.

There is something else that blocks formation before it starts. Fear. Specifically, fear that you will do it wrong. Fear that you will say the wrong thing about God, mishandle a theological question, that your own doubts disqualify you

When my second son was eight, he asked me if God could make a rock so big that He could not lift it. He had heard the question somewhere and it fascinated him. I could have given him the standard philosophical answer about the logical coherence of omnipotence. I did not. I said, that is a question philosophers have asked for a long time, and the short answer is that the question itself is built wrong, like asking if God can make a square circle. But here is what I want you to know. The fact that you are asking hard questions about God means your mind is working the way God designed it to work. Keep asking. I will always try to answer, and when I cannot, we will look for the answer together. He does not remember that conversation. I remember it, because it was one of the moments when I chose honesty over performance. I let him see that his father thinks about hard things and does not pretend they are easy. That was formation. Not the content of the answer. The posture of the answerer.

CHAPTER TWO

The Home Is the Primary Catechism

There is an old word Christian parents should recover. Catechism. Most Protestants have forgotten it, and the ones who keep it treat it as a document — a book of questions and answers a child learns by repetition. That is one meaning. It is not the deepest one. The deepest meaning is the shaping of a person, through rhythms of teaching and life, into what they believe at the level below argument. In that older sense, every home is a catechism. The only question is which one.

Your children are being catechized from the day they are born. If they live in your home, you are the primary catechist. Not the only one. The culture catechizes them. Their friends catechize them. The algorithms they scroll through catechize them with great efficiency. But before any of those, for the critical early years, the catechist is the household. Your house teaches your children something every day about what reality is. The question is whether

Let me be concrete, because this is the chapter where we start naming specifics. A household's catechism runs on four channels, all the time, whether you intend them or not. What the family praises. What the family worries about. What the family repeats. What the family rests in.

THE FOUR CHANNELS

Children notice what their parents praise. Watch a child's eyes when a parent lights up. The child is learning what is worth lighting up about. If the parent lights up about money, the child learns that money is the thing. If the parent lights up about academic performance, the child learns that performance is the thing. If the parent lights up when the child is kind, when the child is honest, when the child is brave for the sake of someone weaker, the child learns something else entirely. I am not saying you should never celebrate a good grade. I am saying the pattern of your celebration is teaching. Your praise is a catechism.

I have watched this run in both directions. I knew a family in one of my earlier churches where the father was a successful businessman. Every achievement the children brought home was measured against his standard of excellence, which was high. The praise flowed when they finished at the top of the class, won the game, got the lead in the play. He was not cruel. He was enthusiastic. He loved his children. And his enthusiasm, over years, catechized them into a theology of performance. God loved you when you performed. God was pleased when you achieved. When one of those children hit a season of failure in their twenties, their faith

I knew another family where the mother praised character. When her daughter told the truth about something that would have been easier to hide, the mother stopped what she was doing, knelt to the girl's level, and said, that is the kind of person God is making you into, and I am proud of you. That was not a formula. It was a reflex. And the reflex catechized the child, day after day, in a theology that had nothing to do with output and everything to do with who she was becoming. That girl is in her late twenties now. She is still walking with Jesus. She will tell you her mother's voice is still the loudest in the room when she has to make a hard decision.

Children read what their parents worry about. They are more attuned to parental anxiety than parents realize. A child knows when you are stressed about the mortgage even if you have never said the word in front of them. A child knows when you are anxious about a social situation, when you fear a particular person's opinion, when you are obsessed with how your life looks to others. And children assume, rightly, that the things their parents worry about are the things worth worrying about. The content of the worry becomes the content of the child's imagined threat. If the home worries about appearance, children grow up afraid of being seen wrong. If the home worries about status, children grow up afraid of being passed over. If the home quietly entrusts these things to God, children learn there is a Father who holds what the world told them to grip.

This does not mean you must never worry. It means you must bring the worry somewhere your children can see. When you are afraid and you take that fear to God, out loud, in the kitchen, where your child can hear you say, Lord, I am anxious about this, and I am bringing it to You because I cannot carry it — you are catechizing your child in the nature of God. You are teaching them, below argument, that there is a Father who receives fear and does something with it. That catechism will run longer and louder than the anxiety, if you practice it.

Children remember what the family repeats. Not what it says once. What it says a thousand times. The prayer over the food that stumbles out the same way every evening. The verse the mother quotes when something breaks. The phrase the father uses when he apologizes. The song that plays in the car. The way Sunday morning starts. These are the liturgies of a household, and they do their work below conscious memory. My own sons will repeat phrases I have said for decades without knowing they are mine. The words will come out of their mouths under pressure, and they will not remember where they heard them. That is catechism. Not content delivery.

James K. A. Smith calls these liturgies, and the word is exactly right. A liturgy is a repeated practice that forms desire. The church has understood this for two thousand years. When you pray the Lord's Prayer weekly, you are not delivering information. You are forming a people whose desires are being shaped by the prayer, even when they are not paying full attention. The same thing happens in a home. When you speak a blessing over your children before bed, you are forming a child whose sense of identity is shaped by the blessing, even when they are half asleep. When you sing the same hymn in the car on the way to church, you are forming their emotional association with worship before they understand what worship is.

The danger of repetition is that it goes empty. The grace before meals that nobody means. The bedtime prayer recited with the parent's foot already out the door. Children know when the repetition has gone hollow. They are not fooled by it. They are catechized by it — and what they learn from hollow repetition is that the words do not matter. That the rituals are performances. That the adults do not believe what they are saying.

The correction is not to stop repeating. It is to mean what you repeat. If the blessing before the meal has gone rote, stop one night and say it fresh. Look your child in the eye and thank God, specifically, for the food, for the family, for the particular mercy that was visible that afternoon. Let the child see that the words connect to something real. That is catechism. The words are the same. The life behind them makes them empty or full.

Children learn what is trustworthy by watching what their parents rest in. When the parent is exhausted, what

*A household's resting point tells you
more about its actual theology than its
stated theology ever will.*

I want to press here, because this is the most revealing of the four. The parent who collapses into a screen every evening is not bad. They are tired. But the child is watching where the tired parent goes, and the child is learning where to go when they are tired. The parent who collapses into prayer, even briefly, even imperfectly, even while exhausted, is teaching the child where the weight goes. I have told my sons, more than once, I am too tired tonight to do much, but I am going to take this to God before I sleep. That is not impressive. It is honest. And honesty at the point of exhaustion is catechism.

So a household catechism is built from four materials. What you praise. What you worry about. What you repeat. What you rest in. The child is writing a book inside them

THE TWO CATECHISMS

Most Christian parents have tried to add content to the catechism without touching the four channels. They sit their children down for devotions at seven in the evening while the household runs all day on anxiety, appearance, and performance. The child receives a mixed signal. Mom praises grades and mentions Jesus. Dad worries about work and says God is in control. The family repeats platitudes the family does not live. The family rests in the phone. And then at seven, everyone opens a Bible together for fifteen minutes. The children receive the data. The catechism has already been written.

This is why so many adults leave the faith of their childhood and say they do not know why. They know why. They were catechized by a household running two catechisms at once. One explicit, one implicit. The explicit one said God is central. The implicit one said God is peripheral. Both could not be true, so when the child grew up, they had to pick which one had been real. They usually picked the implicit one, because implicit lessons feel more honest than explicit ones. That is not rebellion. That is integrity. They believed what the household actually taught.

I have seen this in my own home. There was a period, several years ago, when Susanna and I were running hard. Ministry was demanding. The boys were at ages where everything required logistics. We were physically present and spiritually depleted. We kept doing the family

That was a turning point. The next week, Susanna and I made a decision that changed more in our home than any curriculum ever could. We would tend our own souls first. Before the family devotional. Before the children's ministry. Before the church calendar. We would get our own lives with God back into a sustainable, honest place. We started praying together again, as a couple, not for the family but for ourselves. We started reading Scripture again, not to prepare for anything but to be near God. And as that happened, the four channels began to shift. Not because we added a program. Because the adults in the house changed what they were resting in.

READING YOUR OWN HOUSE

A parent can rewrite the household catechism. Slowly. Not by adding a program. By paying attention to the four channels and beginning to align them with the thing the household says it believes. The first work is honesty about what the house is currently teaching, and that work startles you. When I sat down and watched my own four channels for a week, I found that I praised achievement far more than character. I found that I worried aloud about

Susanna and I sat with that for a while. We did not overhaul the household overnight. We chose one channel at a time. We started with praise, deciding that every day, at least once, we would name character in front of the boys rather than performance. When one of them was kind. When one of them was honest. When one of them was brave in a moment where silence would have been easier. That one shift, sustained over months, changed the feel of the house. Not a new program. A channel that had been running on autopilot.

Worry was harder, because worry is reflexive. You do not decide to worry aloud. It escapes. But when one of us caught ourselves worrying in front of the boys, we learned to follow it with a turn: I am worried about this, and I am bringing it to God because He is the one who holds what I cannot. Not a formula. A discipline. The boys heard it enough that it became part of the household's vocabulary. One of my sons, at age ten, said to his younger brother during a thunderstorm: it is okay to be scared. Dad says you bring the scared thing to God. He had absorbed the catechism.

Repetition was the easiest to change, because it was the most concrete. We chose phrases we wanted to become load-bearing. The blessing over the boys before bed, the old words from Numbers:



– NUMBERS 6:24

A question at dinner: where did you see God today. Not every night. Often enough that they expected it. A sentence Susanna began saying to each boy in the morning: God has a plan for you today. These repetitions, sustained over years, are embedded in my sons now. They will carry those phrases into their own households one day, whether they know it or not. That is catechism.

Rest is the channel we are still working on. It is the hardest, because it touches the deepest part of us. Where do I go when I am depleted. If the honest answer is the phone, the television, or the pantry, then that is what my children are learning is the resting place. Changing that answer requires me to change myself, and that is the deepest work of all.

THE CATECHISM THAT GROWS

The catechism of a household is not static. It changes when the family hits a crisis. It changes when a parent loses a job, when someone gets sick, when a child enters a new stage and the dynamics shift. The catechism you ran when your children were toddlers is not the one you run when they are twelve. The parent who pays attention can adapt the four channels to the new reality instead of running the old catechism on autopilot into a situation it no longer fits.

I noticed this when our boys hit adolescence. The practices that worked when they were small — the bedtime blessing, the dinner question, the Saturday morning Scripture reading — began to feel different. Not wrong.

The four channels are permanent. What you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in — those run for the life of the household. But the content that flows through them must mature. I have seen families lose their teenagers because the parents refused to let it. The practices that formed the children at six were enforced at sixteen with no modification. The teenager, who needed depth and conversation and room to question, was handed the same simple routine they had outgrown years ago. The teenager did not reject the faith. They rejected the version of the faith that was too small for who they were becoming. And the parents, who could not tell the difference, treated the rejection of the small version as a rejection of God.

THE HOUSE THAT IMPLICATES YOU

The reason most parents resist all of this is that it implicates the parent. You cannot change what the household praises without changing what you praise. You

The house will catechize the child either way. The only question is whether it catechizes them toward Christ or away from Him. That is not a question of content. It is a question of alignment, and it points inward before it points outward. I am not writing as a man who has nailed this. I am writing as a man who has been confronted, again and again, with the gap between the catechism my sons say we have and the catechism my weekly life actually teaches them. When the gap narrows, formation follows. When it widens, nothing I say from a pulpit can fix it, and nothing a Sunday school teacher says can fix it either.

The household is the first and most honest seminary a Christian will ever attend. Most of us graduated before we could speak. It is worth asking, slowly, what the curriculum was. And then, with as much honesty as you can bear, what the curriculum is in your own house now.

The next chapter is for the parents who read that and thought: that is the church's job. I want to answer that one directly.

CHAPTER THREE

When the Church Replaces the Parent

I am a pastor. I lead a local church. I love the local church, and I have given my adult life to a particular congregation in a small Michigan town. I say all of that first because of what I am about to argue. If you have handed the spiritual formation of your children to the church you attend, you have made a quiet mistake. And the church has too often been happy to receive what it was never built to carry.

Over the last fifty years, American evangelicalism restructured itself on the assumption that the spiritual formation of children is primarily the church's job. It built an infrastructure to do that job. Age-graded Sunday school. Children's church. Vacation Bible School. Awana. Mid-week kids programs. Youth group. Christian summer camp. Retreats. Mission trips. Every one of those is good in the right proportion. The mistake was not in building them. The mistake was in building them so that parents came to believe this infrastructure was the formation, and

I watch parents do this every week. They drop off a kindergartner on Sunday morning like a dry-cleaning ticket. They pick up a fifth grader at the end of Wednesday night Awana and ask what he earned. They sign a youth-retreat permission slip without ever asking what the retreat is covering. They invest in their children's spiritual life by paying the registration fees and running the carpool. And when those children hit eighteen, twenty, twenty-two, and step away from the faith, the parents are devastated, and they ask what they did wrong. The honest answer is hard. You did everything you were told to do. What you were told to do was never going to produce what you were hoping for.

HOW THE PARENT BECAME THE DELIVERY SYSTEM

This did not happen by accident. The explosion of children's and youth ministry in the second half of the twentieth century was driven by good intentions and market logic. The good intention was to reach young people with the gospel. The market logic was that specialized, age-appropriate programming would do this better than general worship services. Both are partially true. Young people do need to hear the gospel in language they can receive. Age-appropriate teaching does have value. But the market logic carried an assumption nobody challenged: that professional ministry workers, with training and curricula, could form children more effectively than parents could. The parent became the delivery system. The professional became the formator.

Consider what that communicated to the average

That is backwards. It has always been backwards. We are now living in the wreckage of a fifty-year experiment that proved it, because the generation formed primarily in church programs rather than in homes is the generation leaving the faith at historically unprecedented rates. Not because the programs were bad. Because the programs were carrying a weight they were never designed to carry. A youth pastor with forty students, two hours a week, and a six-year window cannot undo or redirect sixteen years of whatever the home has been teaching. The math does not work. It never did.

THE MATH NO ONE DOES

Here is the math most Christian parents have never done. Add up every hour a child is in church programming from birth to age eighteen. Be generous. Sunday morning service plus Sunday school, two hours. Mid-week program, two hours. VBS one week a year, fifteen hours. Youth retreat, forty-eight hours. Camp, a hundred hours. Stack it all up across eighteen years and you come to somewhere between two thousand and four thousand hours, if the family is extremely consistent. Most families are not. Call it three thousand on the high end.

That sounds like a lot until you do the other side of the

Most of you know that in your bones. The problem is you have been trained out of acting on it. You have been led, over years, to believe you are not qualified. The qualified people are the youth pastor, the children's director, the small group leader, the curriculum writer. You are a parent. Parents hand their children to the qualified people, and the qualified people form them. That is the model. It is a bad model, because it assumes the child forms primarily in programmatic environments rather than in the ordinary weight of a home.

I want to name what I have seen from the pastoral side, because parents rarely see it. I have watched gifted children's workers burn out year after year, not because the work was too hard but because the expectation was impossible. The expectation, unspoken but real, was that these workers would produce spiritually mature children out of homes that were not doing the primary work. A children's ministry leader once told me, with tears, that she could not build in two hours what went unbuilt the other hundred and sixty-six hours of the week. She was right. She was carrying a burden that belonged to the parents.

I have also watched youth pastors absorb the blame when a student walked away. The parents looked at the

PARTNER, NOT VENDOR

The church is not the primary catechist of your child. The church is the assembly of believers, including you, gathered around word and sacrament and mission. Your child belongs in that assembly, learns from it, is shaped by it. But the assembly is not a parenting replacement. It is a parenting context. The congregation is the extended family within which you do the primary work, not the contractor you hired to do the work on your behalf.

When parents understand this, two things change. The first is that they stop expecting the youth pastor to do the impossible. A good youth pastor has forty students, forty different family contexts, maybe two hours a week with each one, and a limited window before they graduate. Ask whether two hours a week for six years is enough to redirect sixteen previous years of family-formed assumptions about what life is for. It is not. It never was. You are not being fair to the youth pastor. You are not being fair to your child, who is carrying an expectation you communicated, that this is where formation happens. It is not. And when it does not produce what you hoped, you blame the church, and the church quietly wonders why the Christian home has stopped functioning as a Christian home.

The church is the community in which your home's catechism is confirmed. Your child hears you pray at home and then watches the congregation pray together. Your child watches you serve and then sees other adults serving for the same reasons. Your child hears you talk about grace and then hears the pastor preach grace from the pulpit. The message becomes larger than one household. The church takes the small, private catechism of the home and places it in a larger story. It shows the child that the faith is not a family tradition but a global, historical, living reality their family happens to be part of. That confirmation is essential. The home cannot provide it alone. The church can. That is the partnership.

*Stop treating the youth group as the
load-bearing wall of your child's*

FAITH IS NOT A DEPARTMENT

I want to be careful here, because I do not want to swing too far the other way. There is a family-worship subculture that has overcorrected against the outsourcing model by pulling children out of age-graded ministry entirely, keeping them in the adult service, running rigorous family devotions, and treating the programmatic side of the church as unnecessary or corrupting. That subculture has named a real problem and answered it with a posture that sometimes hardens into isolation and pride. That is not where I am pointing. I am not asking you to withdraw your child from the youth group. I am asking you to stop treating it as the load-bearing wall of your child's faith.

If your home is teaching a true faith and the children are forming near it, a mediocre youth group will not undo that. I have seen it. I have known kids whose youth group was not much, whose parents were quietly serious about Jesus, and those kids grew into men and women whose faith went the distance. I have also seen the opposite. Top-shelf youth ministry. Engaging teaching. Great relationships. And parents whose actual life at home communicated that God is not really the center. Those kids aged out of the youth group, and the faith did not stick, because the youth group was carrying a load the home refused to carry. The youth group cannot win that fight. Nothing can win it except a change at home.

A home doing its own formation work teaches the opposite. Faith is not a department. It is the operating system. It runs in every room, during every conversation, through every decision. The child raised in that home does not know how to separate faith from life, because the two were never separate in his experience. When he leaves for college, the faith goes with him, because the faith is not located in a building or a program. It is located in the way he sees the world. It is in his marrow. He cannot leave it behind.

THE COSTLY HOPE

You get back what you were told you could give away. You are the primary catechist of your children. You do not need a degree. You do not need curriculum certification. You need a life with Christ, the willingness to let your children see that life, and the maturity to bring them into the life of a congregation where that shared life is reinforced and expanded. That is a weight. It does not feel like relief. It feels like the responsibility you thought you had handed off has quietly landed back on your shoulders.

If you are a pastor or a children's worker reading this, you know what I am saying is true. You have been sold to parents as a service. You have sometimes believed the sales copy. You have watched families for years, and you know which ones are forming children and which ones are delegating. It is not the family that is more religiously active in the church. It is the family whose home is running a real catechism. Those children track. Those children come back even if they wander. Those children have something in them that was planted somewhere other than your classroom.

You cannot do their parents' job. You can do your job, which is to come alongside the parent, equip them, encourage them, love them, and serve their children as a partner in what the parent is primarily carrying. Your job is not to be the parent. It never was. When you try, both of you lose, and the child loses worst of all. The church we have built often incentivizes the outsourcing, because it is easier to run a program than to challenge a household, and a child at every event looks like an engaged family on the annual report. We should be measuring formation, not attendance. I am not asking us to dismantle children's ministry. I am asking us to reorient it toward the household, in service of the parents, as a supplement to

WHAT YOU CAN DO TONIGHT

I know many parents reading this are now feeling guilt. You have been dropping your children at church programs and hoping the programs would do the work. The guilt is rising. Here is what I want to say to it. Do not stay there. Guilt that produces change is useful. Guilt that produces paralysis is not. If this chapter has shown you something about your household that needs to change, change it. Do not wallow in what you should have done. Start with what you can do tonight.

Tonight you can sit at the table and ask your children a real question. Tonight you can pray out loud in a room where they can hear you. Tonight you can say the blessing over them before bed. Tonight you can turn off the television and read a passage of Scripture, not because you are performing a devotional but because you want to be near God and you want them to see you wanting it. Those are small things. They are also the entire argument of this book. Small things, done consistently, in a household where the adults are actually walking with Christ, over years, in ordinary rooms. That is the curriculum. You have everything you need to start it tonight.

These words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.

The church gives community, corporate worship, teaching from many voices, the experience of belonging to something larger than the family. The parent gives proximity, daily formation, honest answers, emotional safety, and the lived demonstration of what it looks like to follow Jesus when nobody is watching. Together those two forces produce a formed child. Apart, each is incomplete. The church without the home produces a child who knows about God but has no lived reference for walking with Him in the ordinary. The home without the church produces a child who may know God but has no experience of corporate worship and no connection to the broader body of Christ. You need both. Your child needs both.

So this is the chapter where we stop pretending the church is where this happens. The church is where it is reinforced, celebrated, expanded, and held in common with other families. Where it happens, primarily, is the place no one else can see, where the parent is the one being watched. That is your house. That is your Tuesday at six thirty in the evening. That is the fifteen minutes before your children go to bed. The goal is not to pull your child out of church programs. It is to make sure that when your child walks through those doors on Sunday morning, he walks in from a household where the faith is already alive, not from a household where the faith is on hold until the professionals take over.

Now we turn to what those children are quietly asking while they watch you.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Questions Children Actually Ask

Somewhere around age eight, a child begins to ask real questions. Sometimes earlier. They come at strange moments — in the back of the car, at the dinner table when the conversation was about something else, right before sleep when the child knows the parent cannot easily walk away. The questions are plain on the surface and devastating underneath. If God is good, why did my dog die. If God is real, why did grandma die. Is heaven real. What if I do not feel like I love Jesus. Why are there other religions. How do we know the Bible is true. Why do bad people seem to win. What happens to my friend who does not believe.

How a parent answers in the first ninety seconds tells the child everything. Not about the answer. About whether the question is welcome. And children are taking notes.

Most of us answer too quickly. We answer with a phrase half remembered from a sermon, or a verse that does not

When we do that, we teach the child something far more damaging than the content of our too-quick answer. We teach them that questions do not belong in this household. The child learns, very early, that if there is a question underneath the belief, it has to be hidden from the adults. And because children are not stupid, they keep asking. They just stop asking you. They ask Google. They ask their friends. They ask the algorithm quietly curating the videos they fall asleep to. They ask at two in the morning, to themselves. And they build, over years, a parallel life of unresolved doubt that runs alongside their polite church attendance.

The mechanism matters, so trace it slowly. A child asks a question. The parent's response opens one of two doors. Behind the first, the question is received. The parent's face is open. The parent does not rush. The child learns: this house is a place where I can think about God honestly. The question gets discussed over days or weeks, and the child absorbs not only the content but the posture — faith and questions live in the same room.

Behind the second door, the question is deflected. The parent's face is tight. The answer comes too fast. The child learns: this house is not a place where I can think about God honestly. The question goes underground. The child

The second door is the one producing the crisis we are in. A generation of young adults raised in Christian homes who will tell you, if you ask, that their first honest conversation about faith happened in college. Not because their parents were bad people. Because their parents could not handle the questions. And the children, being loyal, stopped asking.

Eventually one of two things happens. They hit an age, usually between sixteen and twenty-two, where the parallel life overwhelms the church one, and they walk away. Or they keep performing belief while no longer holding it, because they do not want to disappoint the people who clearly could not bear their doubt. Neither outcome is faith. Both are the result of households that could not tolerate a child's honest question.

So reframe it. A child asking you a hard spiritual question is not drifting from faith. Often they are doing the exact opposite. They are trying to make their faith fit the reality they are seeing, and that is a sign of spiritual seriousness, not spiritual weakness. The child who never asks is not the child who has settled faith. The child who never asks is often the child whose curiosity has already migrated elsewhere because the home did not feel safe for it. When your child asks you a hard question, be grateful. It means they still trust you with it. Do not blow that trust by answering in ninety seconds.

THREE SENTENCES THAT ARE REALLY A THEOLOGY

Here is what I have learned raising five sons and pastoring

First. That is a really good question. Not as filler. As an honest response, because the question is a good one. You are welcoming it before you answer it. The child is watching your face while you say it. If your face is honest, the conversation breathes. If your face is tight, the child already knows this was a mistake.

Second. I have wondered that too. Say it only if it is true, and in my experience it will almost always be true. Children ask the questions grown adults ask quietly. If you are a Christian who has never wondered whether God is real, whether suffering makes sense, whether other religions might be right, whether the Bible can be trusted, you are either lying to your child or you are not yet a mature believer. Mature faith has sat with hard questions and come through them to confidence, which is a different thing from never having had the questions. When you tell your child you have wondered what they are wondering, you hand them a gift. You tell them doubt is part of faith, not the opposite of it. You tell them they are not broken for asking.

Third. Let us think about it together. Not: here is the answer. Let us think. That language is slow on purpose. It refuses to perform certainty. It models a believing mind willing to look at the question honestly. It invites the child into the thinking and makes the conversation collaborative rather than corrective. And it often takes more than one conversation, which is the most important thing of all.

Those three sentences work because they are not a technique. They are a theology. The first says: your

*Your authority does not come from
answering every question in real time.
It comes from a God you trust with the
things you cannot answer — and a
child watching you do it.*

THE CANAANITES, AND WHAT I COULD NOT ANSWER

I cannot count the times one of my sons has asked me a question I could not answer well in the moment. A few years ago one of the older ones asked why God commanded the Canaanites to be wiped out in the book of Joshua. He had been reading it on his own — which I want to sit with for a second. He had picked up the Bible on his own, not because I made him but because he had watched me read mine. That is formation. But the question was real. He was eleven. He was bothered. And I did not have a

What I had was the three sentences. That is a really good question. I have wondered that too. Let us think about it together. And then I told him the truth: that I do not think there is a tidy answer, that Christians have wrestled with this passage for two thousand years, that I hold a tentative way of understanding it, and that I wanted to walk through it with him over the coming weeks. We came back to it. More than once. We read some commentators together. I did not resolve it for him. I let him stay with it, with me. That is what formation looks like on a hard question.

Here is what I did not do. I did not pretend I had a clean answer. I did not give him a Sunday school platitude. I did not fast-talk past the difficulty. I did not act like the question itself was unfaithful. And I did not walk away feeling like a failure because I had not converted his question into certainty on my own timeline.

WHEN THE QUESTION IS NOT ABOUT INFORMATION

There is another kind of question entirely, and it asks for a different posture. It is the emotional question — the one that is not really about information at all. It is about pain. A child whose grandfather has died asks if grandpa is in heaven. The child is not asking for a position paper on the intermediate state. The child is asking: is grandpa okay. Will I see him again. Is death the end. And underneath even that: is this world safe. Is there someone holding what hurts.

The Lord is near to the brokenhearted and saves the

— PSALM 34:18

The parent who answers the emotional question with an intellectual answer has missed the child entirely. The child needed a hug first. Tears. To hear that grief is okay and that God is near to the brokenhearted. The theology can come later. The presence comes first.

I have made this mistake. I have answered emotional questions with theological precision when what my son needed was his father's arms and his father's honesty — that death is painful, that we grieve with hope but that the grief is real and we do not have to pretend it is not. The child who receives a lecture when he needed a human presence learns that faith is cold. That is not what we mean to teach. It is what we teach when we reach for our head before we reach for our heart.

Name the most common mistake. It is believing that every hard question requires an immediate settled answer or you have lost your authority. Not true. Your authority does not come from answering every theological question in real time. It comes from your presence, your integrity, your faithfulness over years, and the plain reality that you love your child. You can hold an unresolved question in front of your child for a whole season, and your authority grows rather than shrinks, because you are modeling what a grown believer looks like. Grown believers do not have an answer for everything. They have a God they trust with the things they cannot answer. Modeling that trust, in real time, in front of your child, is one of the most formative things you will ever do.

There is a subtler mistake, and it is harder to see. It is

One category terrifies many Christian parents above the rest: questions about other religions and other worldviews. A child comes home and says her friend is Muslim, or Hindu, or atheist, and wants to know why the friend believes something different and whether the friend is wrong. This terrifies the parent who has been taught that exposure to other worldviews is dangerous. But the question is not dangerous. The question is the beginning of apologetics.



Always be prepared to give an answer to everyone who asks you to give the reason for the hope that you have. But do this with gentleness and respect.

— 1 PETER 3:15

The child is asking you to give a reason for the hope that is in you. If you cannot do it with gentleness and respect, as Peter commanded, the child will conclude that your faith cannot withstand comparison. That conclusion is devastating — and it is reached not through exposure to other religions but through the parent's inability to engage them.

So answer the actual question. If you do not know, say so. If it is complicated, say so. If there is more than one Christian position, name it. You are not required to pretend the tradition is monolithic. Children are impressed, not destabilized, by a parent who says: there

WHAT FIFTEEN YEARS OF OPEN DOORS PRODUCES

I have watched what happens when a household handles questions well over years. The child raised in a home where questions are welcome does not stop asking. They ask better ones. At eight it is why did the dog die. At twelve, how do we know the resurrection happened. At sixteen, what do we do about suffering in the world. At nineteen, how do I hold my faith when my roommate's arguments are good. The progression is striking when the door has stayed open, because at every stage the child's faith is being refined by the questions rather than eroded by them.

The questions do to faith what fire does to gold. They burn away what is false and leave what is true. A child whose questions have been welcomed for fifteen years has a faith that has been tested, and a tested faith is a faith that lasts.

I have also watched the opposite. The child raised where questions are unwelcome does not stop having questions. They go underground. They multiply in the dark. They attach to resentment. And when the child finally finds an environment where the questions are welcomed — a college classroom, an online community — that environment feels more honest than home. Not because the professor has better answers. Because the professor did what the parent would not: treated the

So build question-asking into the rhythms of the household. Do not wait for questions to surface at random. Make spaces where they are expected. At the dinner table, ask what your children are thinking about — not what they learned at school, what they are thinking about. At bedtime, after the prayer, ask if there is anything they have been wondering about. On car rides, turn off the music for ten minutes and ask. You will get silence at first. You will get shrugs. Keep asking. Over weeks and months the child begins to believe you mean it. And when they believe you mean it, the questions come. They come to you, which is the whole point.

START NOW, WHILE THE QUESTIONS ARE SMALL

The hope in this chapter is plain and heavy. Be the safe person your child can ask the hardest question of their life now, so that ten years from now, when the question is the one that will decide whether they stay in the faith, they are still coming to you with it. Not to Google. Not to the friend who is also confused. To you.

That means starting now, when they are six and eight and ten and the questions are small enough to practice on. If you cannot handle a small question now, you will not be the one they trust with the large one later. And the large question is coming. It always does.

Some of you are parents of teenagers who have already stopped asking. You feel the loss. You know when the questions went underground. You wonder if it is too late. It

Your children have questions. Thousands of them. Most of them do not yet know what those questions will grow into. You cannot give them certainty. But you can give them a seat at your table while they work it out, with a Bible open between you and the Holy Spirit doing what He does best, which is drawing people to Christ in the slow and honest way.

The questions children ask change as they grow, and the parent who handles a six-year-old well can be caught off guard by a twelve-year-old. Young children ask concrete questions. Where is heaven. What does God look like. Can God see me in the dark. These are spatial, physical, imagination-level questions. They are trying to locate God in the world they can see. The parent's job here is to be concrete in return. God is everywhere, but He is especially close to you when you pray. God does not have a body like ours, but Jesus did, and Jesus looks at you with love. Yes, God can see you in the dark, and He is watching over you right now. Direct. Warm. The child is not looking for sophistication. They are looking for assurance that God is real and God is near.

Older children ask moral questions. Why did God let the dog die. Why are there poor people if God loves

Teenagers ask identity questions. How do I know God is real and not just something I believe because my parents do. Why should the Bible have authority over my life when other smart people call it mythology. What makes Christianity different from any other religion that claims to be true. These are existential questions. The teenager is not trying to be difficult. They are trying to own their beliefs rather than borrow yours. And the parent who reacts with fear or anger confirms the teenager's suspicion that the faith cannot survive examination.

I have seen parents panic at this stage. They hear their teenager voice doubt and treat it as a crisis. They call the youth pastor. They ground the child. They add to the Bible reading schedule. Every one of those responses says the same thing: your honest questions are dangerous, and the adults in your life are afraid of them. That is not formation. That is suppression. And suppression yields one of two ends. Either the child hides the questions, which means they fester underground. Or the child escalates them into

THE YEAR MY SON TESTED HIS FAITH

The better response is to welcome the question and honor the questioner. When my son asked me, at fourteen, how he could know God was real and not just something he believed because his father was a pastor, I felt pride before I felt anything else. Because that question meant he was doing the work. He was not content to carry a borrowed faith. He wanted his own. And getting his own required testing the one he had been given.

I told him several things. That his question was one of the best a person can ask, and that I was glad he was asking it. That I had asked the same question when I was not much older than him, and that my faith had survived the asking. That there are good reasons to believe God is real and Christianity true, reasons articulated by some of the brightest minds in human history, and that I would gladly walk through some of them with him. And that faith is not the absence of doubt. Faith is trust in the face of doubt. The God of the Bible is not threatened by honest questions. He invites them.

We spent the next several months reading together. Not the Bible, at first. We read parts of C. S. Lewis. We read parts of Tim Keller. We watched some lectures. We talked about what he found persuasive and what he did not. And somewhere in those months, something shifted. He moved from testing a borrowed faith to building his own. The content was much the same. The ownership was different. And that difference is everything.

Some questions come without words. A child who starts

These behavioral questions are harder to hear than spoken ones, because the behavior triggers the parent's frustration rather than their curiosity. The parent sees the lie and responds to the lie. Sees the withdrawal and takes it personally. Sees the acting out and reaches for discipline. In each case the parent is answering the surface behavior rather than the question underneath it.

The parent who can look past the behavior to the question is the parent who can actually form the child. That does not mean the behavior goes unaddressed. It means the behavior is addressed after the question has been heard. You lied to me, and we need to talk about that. But first I want to understand something. Are you afraid of what happens when you tell me the truth? Because if you are, that is something I need to change about how I respond to you. That kind of response forms a child. It teaches them that the adults in their life are paying attention to the person, not managing the performance.

Underneath all of this lies another issue — one that shapes whether the child is even asking for truth or asking for permission. That is the next chapter. Obedience without gospel.

CHAPTER FIVE

Obedience Without Gospel

There is a particular brand of Christian parenting that raises atheists. It does not mean to. It comes from parents who love their children and believe they are doing the most serious work of their lives. They are. They are running the wrong version of it. The version produces a child who behaves well, checks the right boxes, gives the parent no trouble, and somewhere around age twenty quietly concludes that the whole thing was about compliance and that he has outgrown it.

Name it. The version is obedience without gospel. It treats the Christian life as a set of behaviors the child must perform. Do not do this. Do this. Memorize these verses. Avoid those people. Stay in church, off the phone, dressed a certain way, speaking a certain way. The content of the rules varies by tribe; the logic is the same. If the child complies, the child is spiritually healthy. If the child does not comply, the child is spiritually sick. The parent's job, in

This model has two problems. The first is that it is not the gospel. It is moralism with Christian vocabulary. The second is that even when it works, it produces the wrong kind of person. The point of the Christian life is not a well-behaved child. The point is a child whose heart has been confronted with the love of God and has learned to love God back. Behavior flows out of that. Behavior engineered without it is a hollow performance that holds until adolescence and then breaks.

If you get the behavior without the heart, you have not succeeded. You have delayed a crisis. It comes, usually when the child is old enough to resent a control he cannot remember agreeing to. And when it comes, he is not throwing away a relationship with Jesus. He never had one. He was performing a relationship with his parents, and the moment he could get out from under that performance, he did. He was right to. The performance was never the real thing.

TWO SPECIES OF OBEDIENCE

Many parents running this model do not know they are running it. They think they are teaching their children the faith. They are teaching a behavioral system that borrows the faith's vocabulary. The difference is everything, and it shows up in the smallest moments.

A child lies to a parent. The moralist parent responds: lying is a sin, God does not like it, you will be punished, do not do it again. The gospel parent starts somewhere else. First the relationship: I love you, you are safe here. Then

The child raised on the first version learns that God is a rule enforcer: stay in line or face consequences. The child raised on the second learns that God is a father who loves him and is forming him. The obedience that flows from the second is a different species than the first. Fear-driven obedience expires the moment the enforcer is removed. Love-driven obedience deepens the moment the person is alone, because it is internally held, not externally coerced.

I see the fruit of this in my pastoral work constantly. A couple comes to me grieving a grown child who has walked away. The story is always the same in its outline. We raised him in the church. We had family devotions. He was respectful, well-behaved, a good student. He went on mission trips. Then he got to college and something broke, and we do not know what happened. I ask careful questions. Almost every time, what emerges is that the faith the child grew up with was a behavioral contract enforced by parental pressure with gospel language draped over it. The child was not apostate. He was released from a contract the moment the enforcer left the room.

I have sat with enough of these parents to see the pattern. They can name every program the child attended. They can name the baptism date and the commitment card from camp. They cannot name the last time the child

NEWS BEFORE COMMAND

Reframe it. The gospel is not a set of behaviors. The gospel is the announcement that God has acted in Christ to rescue people who cannot rescue themselves. It is news before it is command. The commands follow. They do not precede. They do not substitute.

The moral life of a Christian is a response to the news, lived out of the power the news releases, which is the Holy Spirit at work in a heart brought into relationship with God through Christ. This is the order. News first. Then relationship. Then changed behavior. Not the reverse. Reverse it, which is what much of American Christian parenting does, and you produce a child who has never heard good news. He has only heard demand. He has heard you say Jesus loves you, but the texture of the household told him Jesus accepts you if you behave, that God's love is transactional and conditional and tied to performance. That is not the gospel. It is the opposite of the gospel. And children raised on the opposite of the gospel will, at their first real chance, reject it, because it is exhausting news dressed up in Christian language.

I need to name something hard. The moralist model is attractive because it produces visible, measurable results. A well-behaved child is a relief. A compliant child is socially acceptable. A child who never questions, never pushes back, never makes a scene is one the parent can

Compliance and formation are not the same thing. Sometimes they overlap. Sometimes they do not. The only way to know is to look at the heart, and the heart is not visible in behavior alone.

Your child's obedience is not the measure of your parenting. I know that contradicts certain Christian parenting books. I mean it anyway. Your child's heart is the measure, and you cannot control your child's heart. You can tend the soil. You can preach the gospel in ordinary language over years. You can be the kind of person near whom heart change is more likely than not. You cannot force it. And if you mistake external compliance for heart change, you will be satisfied with something God is not satisfied with. You will stop pressing in where it actually matters. You will be relieved by the quiet child and alarmed by the one struggling openly, when it may be the struggling one who is alive and the quiet one who has learned to perform.

Here is what gospel parenting looks like in practice. When your child fails, which will happen every day, the first word out of your mouth is not correction. The first word is grace. That does not mean no correction. Correction comes. But it comes inside a frame that says: nothing you can do will make me love you more, and nothing you can do will make me love you less. You are secure here. And so is the case with God.

He loves you. He is not waiting for you to get it right before He loves you. He loves you enough to do the slow work of forming you into someone whose heart actually wants what He wants. That is the direction we are going. Not perfect behavior. Formed heart. Everything we do in this house is toward that.

Your children will test whether you mean it. They will do things that trigger your moralism, that expose whether your first instinct is control or grace. And you will fail. I have. Many times. The test is not whether you get it right the first time. The test is whether you are willing to go back and repair. A parent who blows up at a child in moralistic anger and then comes alongside that child and says, I am sorry, I responded out of my own frustration, that is not how God meets you, let me tell you how He actually meets you, that parent is teaching the gospel in that moment. The failure, handled with repentance, is the lesson. The parent who never fails cannot teach the gospel, because the gospel is for failures, and if your children think you have never been one, they will not know how to be one in your presence. They will hide from you the parts of themselves God most wants to meet.

THE COST OF TRUSTING THE SILENCE

Do not over-correct the other way. I have seen parents react against moralism by removing all structure, all correction, all expectation. That is not gospel parenting. That is permissive parenting with Christian language. Gospel parenting has real correction, real discipline, real consequences. What it does not have is correction without love, consequences without explanation, discipline without repair.

The gospel does not remove the law. It fulfills it. It changes why we obey. We do not obey to be loved. We obey because we are loved. The structure in your home remains; the source of the structure changes. It is not earning. It is responding. Your children need to see a home where the rules make sense because of who God is and what He has done, not because mom and dad demand it. If you cannot answer the question why in your own rules at a level deeper than because I said so, your rules are not formation. They are control. And control produces the very rebellion you feared, the moment your children are

I practiced this with one of my sons when he was eleven. He had read the Bible nightly with me since he was old enough to sit still. One week he said he did not want to. He said it was boring, that he did not see the point. My instinct was to lecture him about the importance of Scripture, which is moralism dressed as discipleship. Instead I said: I hear you. Reading the Bible can feel boring. It has felt boring to me too. I am not going to make you read tonight. But I am going to keep reading, and if you want to talk about what I am reading, I am here. He did not read for three weeks. On the fourth week he sat down next to me while I was reading and asked what the passage was about. We talked for thirty minutes. He has read on his own since.

What happened in those three quiet weeks was not a failure of formation. It was formation. He learned that his father's love for Scripture did not depend on his participation. He learned the Bible was something his father wanted, not something his father was administering. He learned the relationship between us was not contingent on spiritual compliance. The moralist household fears silence. The gospel household trusts it, because it knows the Holy Spirit is at work in the silence, and the parent's job is not to fill that silence with pressure but with presence.

That trust costs the parent something. It costs control. It costs the assurance that the child is performing correctly. It requires the parent to trust God with the child's interior life rather than managing that interior life through enforcement. And that costly trust is itself formation. The child who watches a parent trust God with

THE THEOLOGY YOUR CHILD WILL CARRY

Here is the thing that grieves me most as a pastor. The moralist model produces adults who cannot receive grace. They were raised in a system where performance was the currency and grace was the reward for good behavior. When they fail as adults, and they will, they do not know how to bring failure to God. They hide it. They perform harder. They white-knuckle their way through guilt, because the only model they have for failure is to work harder, produce more, and earn their way back into favor. That is not the Christian life. It is its exhausting counterfeit, and it produces burnout, hidden sin, and collapsed faith in the middle of adulthood.

I have counseled adults in their forties who cannot pray after a moral failure because they believe, at the gut level, that God is disappointed in them the way their parents were disappointed in them at age nine. The disappointment was the catechism. The gospel was the footnote. And the footnote did not survive adulthood. I have heard versions of this from people who grew up in moralist homes, where the child's spiritual life became fused with the parent's emotional state. God was happy when Mom was happy. God was disappointed when Dad was worried. The parent became the functional mediator, and Christ, the actual mediator, was crowded out.

The way you respond to your child's failure today is

You are not raising children. You are raising adults. The adults you are raising will carry the theology of your home into their own homes, their own marriages, their own failures, their own encounters with God. What they carry will either free them or bind them. The gospel frees. The moralist counterfeit binds. Preach the gospel in your house, to your children, by name, often. Let it be the center, so the behaviors become fruit rather than root. Raise children whose obedience grows from love rather than fear. That takes years. It will not appear on any one metric. But it produces something that lasts when the child is finally out of your reach. Not compliance. Conviction. Not performance. Formed loves.

CHAPTER SIX

Discipline, Correction, and the Shape of Grace

Every parent disciplines. The question is not whether you will correct your children. The question is what your correction is forming in them. Correction, like everything else in the household, is catechesis. The way you handle a child's failure teaches that child something about who God is, what sin does, how grace operates, and whether restoration is real. Get those four wrong and you will produce a child with a distorted image of God that no sermon will easily undo.

Most Christian households discipline reactively. The child does something wrong, and the parent responds out of whatever he is feeling in that moment, which is usually some mix of anger, embarrassment, fear, and exhaustion. The punishment fits the parent's emotional state more than it fits the offense. And the child learns, over hundreds

In twenty years of pastoral counseling I have watched two patterns do this damage. Both come from parents who love their children. Both produce wounded theology anyway.

TWO WAYS TO WOUND A CHILD

The first is wrath-based correction. The child sins. The parent erupts — loud, sometimes physical, always out of proportion to the offense. The child is scared. The parent eventually calms down. The incident is never revisited and no repair is made. The child learns: when I sin, God erupts. God is angry. God is unpredictable. God calms down eventually, but the eruption is what I remember. This is a theology of fear. The child obeys because he dreads the explosion, not because he loves. And the fear produces one of two children — the one rigid and terrified of any mistake, or the one who learns to hide everything, because hiding is safer than being seen.

I have met adults in their forties who still flinch internally when they pray, because the God they are praying to sounds like the father who screamed at them when they were nine. That father did not mean to teach it. He was angry. He was also, in many cases, repeating what had been done to him. Wrath-based correction runs through generations until someone breaks it. And breaking it requires hearing the one thing an angry parent does not want to hear: the anger is his problem, not the child's, and bringing unprocessed anger into the correction of a child is sin.

I have been in this indictment. I have raised my voice at

That repair is essential, and it is deeply uncomfortable. A father who goes back to his son and admits that his anger, not the child's behavior, was the problem is a father losing the illusion of infallibility that many men cling to. But the illusion was never serving the child. It was serving the father's ego. And the ego is not the basis of parental authority. Christ is.

The second pattern is withdrawal-based correction. The child sins. The parent does not erupt. The parent goes cold — withdraws affection, becomes distant. The child feels it and learns: when I sin, love is removed. God pulls back when I fail. The distance grows when I am bad and shrinks when I am good. This is subtler than wrath, and in some ways more damaging, because it teaches the child that God's love is conditional, that the cross did not settle the question of God's affection, that you must earn your way back into the warm place.

Withdrawal does not look as dramatic as wrath. It looks calm. It looks controlled. But the child raised by a parent who goes cold after a failure learns something devastating about love itself: that it has conditions, that closeness must

PAIDEIA: THE TRAINER, NOT THE JUDGE

Hebrews 12 is the text most Christian parents know on this subject.

| *The Lord disciplines those He loves.*

— HEBREWS 12:6

That is true. But the verse sits inside a passage about endurance, about running the race, about the great cloud of witnesses. The discipline of the Lord here is not punitive. It is formative — the discipline of a trainer, not a judge. The Greek word is *paideia*: training, instruction, the formation of a child. It is the same word the classical world used for the education of the young. It carries the idea of a father investing in a child's growth over years. It does not carry the idea of a father punishing a child into submission.

This distinction decides everything. Punitive discipline asks how do I stop this behavior. Formative discipline asks how do I use this moment to shape who this child is becoming. The first is about control; the second about growth. The first produces compliance or rebellion. The second produces a child learning, over years, to see his

Here is what that looks like in a home. The child fails, and the parent responds not from anger but from purpose. He is clear about what happened. You lied. You hit your brother. You disobeyed what we agreed on. No minimizing, no euphemism. The child needs the truth about what he did, because truth is what God gives, and it is a gift even when it hurts. Then the parent names why it matters — not because I said so, but because lying breaks trust, because violence wounds a person made in God's image, because obedience in this house is not about my power but about the kind of person God is forming you into. The why ties the behavior to something larger than the parent's preference: the character of God and the dignity of other people.

Then the consequence, because consequences are real in a gospel household. Grace does not mean no consequences. It means consequences inside the context of unbreakable love. The child loses a privilege, makes restitution, apologizes to the person he hurt. The consequence is proportionate, clear, and tied to the behavior — not random, not excessive, not designed to inflict pain but to teach. And then comes the part most Christian parents skip: the repair. After the consequence, the parent comes back. Not grudgingly, not with lingering coldness, but with warmth. That is done. You have been corrected. You are still loved. Nothing has changed about your place in this family, and nothing has changed about God's love for you. Let us keep going.

The repair is what teaches the child the

A household that practices all four is teaching its children the shape of grace. The shape of grace is not that sin does not matter. It is that sin matters enormously, and God has dealt with it in Christ, and because He has dealt with it you are not defined by it and can grow through it rather than being destroyed by it. That is the most important thing a child can learn about the moral life. And he will learn it not from a theology class but from the way his parents handle his Tuesday evening failure.

THE ANGER IS ABOUT YOU

I want to address the parent's anger directly, because it is the elephant in most Christian homes. Your anger at your child's behavior is usually about you. About your embarrassment that he acted that way in public. About your fear that you are failing. About your need for control. About your own unprocessed wounds from your own childhood. It is rarely, in the moment, about the child's formation. And a correction delivered in anger is a correction the child receives as attack, not love. He will not hear the content of your correction over the volume of your fury.

This does not mean you should never feel anger. When

Here is a practice I learned late and wish I had learned early. When one of my sons does something that triggers my anger, I pause. Not because I am serene. Because I know from experience that the words I say in the first ten seconds of anger are the words my son will remember for years. If I want those words to form him rather than wound him, I have to choose them instead of react with them. The pause is not natural. It is learned. And it is one of the most important disciplines a parent can develop, because it is the discipline of bringing your own flesh under the authority of the Spirit before you try to bring your child under the authority of the household.

Let me also address the spanking question, since it comes up in every conversation about Christian discipline. I am not going to tell you whether to spank your children. I am going to tell you what I have seen. Where spanking was calm, controlled, infrequent, tied to specific behaviors, and followed by immediate repair and affection, the children were not notably different from children corrected other ways. Where spanking was administered in anger, frequently, as the primary mode, without repair, the children were afraid of their parents and associated God with physical pain. The issue was never the method. It was the spirit behind it. Any discipline delivered in wrath, physical or verbal, teaches a theology of wrath. Any

The costly hope in this chapter is that you can change. If you have been a wrathful parent, you can repent. If you have been a withdrawing parent, you can learn to stay close. If your discipline has been reactive, you can make it purposeful. And the repair for what you have already done begins with honesty. Go to your child. Name what you did. Apologize for the spirit behind it. Tell him what God's correction actually looks like. Then begin, today, to correct differently. Children are remarkably forgiving when the repentance is real. They have been waiting for you to see what they have been seeing for years. When you see it and name it, the relationship does not weaken. It strengthens — because the child learns that even the parent is under God's formation, and that gives him permission to be under it too.

ONE HOUSE, ONE VOICE

Something comes up in nearly every conversation I have with parents about discipline: consistency between the two of them. One of the most damaging things in a child's formation is a household where the two parents discipline differently, where the child learns to play one against the other, and where correction feels arbitrary because it depends on which parent caught the behavior.

This happens in almost every two-parent home. One parent is stricter, the other more lenient. One responds with heat, the other with calm. One follows through on consequences, the other forgets or relents. And the child, who is watching everything, learns that the moral structure of the household is not stable — it shifts

The correction is not that both parents become identical. Temperamental differences are real and they are not going away. The correction is alignment. The two need a conversation, away from the children, about what the household's discipline is for. What are we trying to form. What are the non-negotiable behaviors. What are the proportionate consequences. And when one of us is in the moment with a child, what does the other one do. That conversation, had in advance, prevents the breakdown that happens when two parents try to improvise a response in real time while the child watches.

I will tell you where Susanna and I failed and what we learned. Early on we had no alignment. I was the stricter parent; she was more lenient. The boys learned fast that if Dad said no, there was a chance Mom would say yes if they caught her at the right moment. We were being played — not maliciously. Children are natural strategists. They find the weak point in any system and exploit it. That is not sin; that is intelligence. The problem was that our system had a weak point, and the weak point was us.

After a particularly chaotic day we sat down one evening and made a rule that changed everything. If one parent has made a decision about discipline, the other backs it in front of the child. Always. Even when the other disagrees. The disagreement happens later, in private, between the two of us. But in front of the child the response is unified. This did not mean we always agreed. It meant the child always saw agreement, and that consistency gave the household a stability it had lacked.

CORRECT IN PRIVATE, FORM THE PERSON

I also want to address public correction versus private correction, because it matters more than most parents realize. A child corrected in front of his siblings, his friends, or other adults receives not only the correction but the shame of being corrected publicly. And shame is not conviction. Conviction says you did something wrong and here is how to make it right. Shame says you are wrong and everyone can see it.

Whenever possible, correct in private. Pull the child aside. Take him to another room. Speak where his siblings cannot hear. This communicates respect. It communicates that the purpose of the correction is his formation, not his humiliation, and it removes the social pressure that turns a formative moment into a shaming one. There are exceptions. When a child's behavior is dangerous or harmful in the moment, immediate correction is necessary. When a child is defiant in a way that affects the whole household, the household needs to see it addressed. But even then the detailed conversation — the why, the consequence, the repair — belongs in private. The public

One more thing I learned late and wish I had learned early. The most effective discipline I have ever administered was not the strictest. It was the most connected. The correction that changed my son's behavior most was not the one with the biggest consequence. It was the one where he felt most known — where I named what he did, connected it to who he was becoming, applied a consequence that made sense, and then held him. Where the whole sequence, from naming to repair, took place inside a relationship he knew was unbreakable.

Children will accept correction from someone they trust. They will resist correction from someone they fear. And the difference between trust and fear is not the severity of the consequence. It is the quality of the relationship. A parent who has invested in the relationship, who has been present, who has listened, who has played and laughed and been available, has earned the right to correct. And the child, who knows he is loved by that parent, receives the correction as love rather than punishment. Build the relationship first. The discipline that follows a strong relationship will form character. The discipline that precedes or replaces relationship will form resentment.

Your discipline is forming something. Either a child who understands grace or a child who fears God — not the holy fear of Scripture, which is awe in the presence of holiness, but the other kind. The fear that flinches. The fear that hides. The fear that will not come near. That fear is not the fruit of Christian parenting. It is the fruit of parenting that forgot the gospel at the moment it mattered

So correct your children. Do it clearly, honestly, proportionately, and with repair. Do it so that when your child thinks about what God is like, the first thing he remembers is not your anger but your steadiness, your honesty, your willingness to call the thing what it is and to love him through it anyway. That is the shape of grace. That is what the home is supposed to teach. Now we need to talk about the thing that is catechizing your child more hours a day than you are. We need to talk about their phone.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Screens, Algorithms, and the Catechesis of Attention

You cannot write a book about forming faith in children in 2026 and pretend the old questions are the only ones. They are not. For many hours of most days, your child's primary catechist is not you. It is an algorithm trained to hold their attention by any means available, and whatever it is forming in them competes directly with whatever you are trying to form. You should know what you are up against.

A smartphone is not a television. It is not a radio, not a video game. Those are older technologies, and a generation of Christian parents has tried to govern the new one with the old rules. Limit screen time. Use parental controls. Put the computer in a central room. Those rules worked, imperfectly, in the old world. They are insufficient in this one, because the smartphone is a different kind of

If that sounds like overstatement, read the public testimony of the engineers who built these systems. Many of them have said they do not let their own children use the platforms they made. They know what those platforms do, because they built them to do it. These are not neutral tools your child uses for homework and occasionally for fun. They are formation environments with a theology of the human person, and their theology is that the person is a consumer of stimulus whose attention is a resource to be extracted.

That theology stands in direct opposition to the Christian one. The Christian one says the person is a soul made for communion with God, whose attention is a gift to be given back to the Creator in worship and to the neighbor in love. The phone's theology says your attention is yours only in the legal sense, and it exists to be harvested. Both cannot shape your child at the same rate. One will win. If your child receives forty-five minutes of the Christian theology on Sunday morning and six hours a day of the other one, the math is not complicated.

WHAT THE DEVICE IS DOING

Most parents think the danger is content. They worry about what their child is seeing. They should. But the deeper danger is structural. It is what the device is doing to their child's capacity for the kind of attention that faith

Jonathan Haidt has documented this at length. The adolescent mind is being reshaped by a platform-based childhood in ways that produce unprecedented anxiety, depression, and attention fragmentation. These are not incidental side effects. They are the natural result of training a developing brain on intermittent variable reinforcement, the same mechanism that makes slot machines addictive. The platform delivers a reward, withholds a reward, delivers a larger one, withholds again. The brain chases. The chasing becomes the state of mind. The child is not choosing to be distracted. The child's brain has been trained to be distracted, and the distraction is now the default.

This has spiritual consequences most Christian parents have not considered. Prayer requires sustained attention. So does Scripture. So does listening to a sermon, sitting in silence with God, confessing, repenting. Every practice of the Christian life depends on a capacity the smartphone is systematically dismantling in your child. You are trying to form a child in a faith that requires slow, focused, interior attention, and the device in their pocket is training their brain in the exact opposite direction. The device is winning. Not because it is smarter than you. Because it has more hours.

I am not saying no phones. I am not saying throw out the internet. I am a pastor who communicates daily through these tools. My sons have earned graduated levels of device access over time. I am not a Luddite. I am saying something narrower. If you do not have a deliberate theology of attention for your household, the platforms have one for you, and they are winning. Name it. Act on it.

ATTENTION IS A SPIRITUAL MATTER

The historic Christian tradition has understood this for centuries. The capacity to attend to God, to the neighbor, to the word of Scripture, to one's own soul, is the substrate of the Christian life. The saints trained it. They treated attention as a muscle that strengthens through use and atrophies through neglect. A scattered mind cannot easily pray, cannot easily love, cannot easily meet God in Scripture. They did not have our devices, but they knew what a disordered soul does when it has no disciplines of attention. It becomes shallow. It becomes frantic. It becomes incapable of the long, slow, quiet attention God requires.

Simone Weil wrote that prayer is attention, and she meant it technically. The capacity to hold one's mind before God, without distraction, without chasing the next stimulus, is the very thing prayer is. A child raised on a device that delivers a new stimulus every few seconds is being trained, all day, in the opposite direction. The child is being formed in a rhythm. Short. Shorter. Shortest. Stimulus, stimulus, stimulus. No silence. No boredom. No waiting. That is catechesis. The child who cannot tolerate five minutes of silence cannot be still before God. The child who cannot tolerate a slow story cannot read a Gospel. The child whose reward circuits have been trained by infinite scroll cannot easily accept that faith is a long obedience. You are not working against a neutral baseline. You are working against a trained one.

And the device is not only training attention. It is training desire. The algorithm learns what your child

You stand between your child and a system built to harvest them. Stand there. It is one of the most pastoral things a parent can do.

WHAT TO DO, AND WHAT IT WILL COST

Make peace with the fact that this will be harder than you wanted. You will not solve it with a weekend family conversation. You will have to take a stand that costs you, and your child will resent you for a while, because you are asking them to do what their peers are not, and peer

Delay, and delay hard. The research on adolescent phone use is not ambiguous, and delaying a personal smartphone into the teenage years is one of the most load-bearing decisions you will make. A dumb phone or a watch for safety is fine. A smartphone with social media and infinite access is not. Hold it back until your child is old enough to have some chance of using it with formed resistance, which is not twelve, not thirteen, and in most cases older than you would like. You will be in a minority. You are already in a minority by pursuing serious Christian formation. This is one of the places the minority is right.

Keep devices out of bedrooms. Every device, including yours. The bedroom is a sanctuary, and nothing that wants a piece of your child's attention at two in the morning gets into that room. This rule is among the hardest to keep, because parents are the ones who break it. If you want your children to leave their phones downstairs at nine, you will leave yours there too. Your phone is catechizing you at the same hours it is catechizing them. The rule applies all the way up.

Replace before you remove. Taking screens away without offering something that meets the human need the screen was meeting is a setup for failure. A bored child will find a way back, because nature abhors a vacuum. A child needs embodied life: physical work outside, time with animals, time with older people and younger ones, projects that take weeks, real books, long walks, hand tools, sports played for love rather than trophies,

Model it, because you will not win any of this if your own attention is captured. Your children watch you reach for the phone at the first break in conversation. They watch you disappear into it at dinner, watch you fill every quiet moment with input. They are being catechized by your relationship with your device as much as by their own. So put phones in a basket during dinner. Keep yours out of the bedroom. Take one day a week of severely limited use. Sit with your own Bible, in paper, at a table, where the children can see you doing it. You cannot hand them a relationship with God while modeling a relationship with your phone that is more intimate than your relationship with God. They will read the real one.

And talk about it openly, because your children are not blind. They often know more than you do about what the platforms are doing to them. Come to them in humility: I want us, as a family, to think carefully about how these devices are forming us, and I want your help figuring out what is wise. You will get a more honest conversation than you expect. Children resent rules imposed from outside. They respond to an invitation to think together about a real problem. Let some of the rules come from them. They will keep rules they helped design longer than ones that came down from above.

The costly hope is that attention can be retrained. It is slow and it is difficult, but a child whose attention has

THE PHONE AS A WORSHIP DEVICE

There is one more dimension to this, because it touches worship in a way most parents have not considered. Worship is not a Sunday activity. Worship is the orientation of a person's deepest attention toward whatever they regard as most worthy. The phone is a worship device. It trains attention. It directs desire. It forms what the user regards as most worthy of their time, their emotion, their energy. When a child spends four hours a day on a device, they are being formed in worship. The only question is what they are worshipping.

The algorithm does not care about your child's soul. It cares about engagement. It measures what your child watches longest, clicks most, responds to most strongly, and feeds them more of it. Over time it learns your child better than your child knows themselves. It knows their fears, their insecurities, their triggers, and it exploits all of them. Not because the algorithm is evil in a moral sense, but because it is designed to capture attention, and captured attention is the raw material of profit.

When Paul wrote that we should take every thought captive to Christ, he was describing what happens when a person's attention is rightly oriented. The phone does the opposite. It takes every thought captive to the feed. And a child whose thoughts are captive to the feed is a child

The Christian answer is not to ban all technology. That is neither possible nor wise. The answer is to teach your child to think about attention the way a disciple thinks about worship. Where is your attention going. What is it forming in you. Is the thing that has your attention worthy of it. Is it making you more like Christ or less. Those questions, asked regularly, in a household where the parents are asking them about their own attention, produce a child who can use technology without being used by it. That distinction, between use and mastery, is the one Paul makes:

All things are lawful for me, but I will not be mastered by anything.

— 1 CORINTHIANS 6:12

When I see my sons on their phones for a long stretch, I have started asking a different question. Not how long have you been on that. What is that doing to you. The first question is about time. The second is about formation, and it invites the child to consider what is happening inside them, not what they owe me in compliance. They do not

TO THE PARENT WHO ALREADY HANDED IT OVER

I want to close with a word to the parent who has already given the phone over and is now trying to get it back. Undoing a decision is harder than making one, and the parents living inside the regret of premature screen access need more than guilt.

You are not the only one. You are not even in the minority. Most parents I counsel gave their children a device earlier than they now wish. They did it because the child was the last in the friend group without one, because the school required it, because the child was bored and the parent was tired and the screen was the easiest answer, because they did not know what the device would do to a child's attention, sleep, social development, and spiritual life. Now they know, and the knowing feels like an indictment.

Let me offer something other than guilt. You made a decision with incomplete information. The research on adolescent mental health and smartphone use has moved fast in the last several years. What we know now, we did not know five years ago, and what little we did know was not being communicated clearly by the people selling the devices. You are not a bad parent for that decision. You are

There is no Christian formation without trained attention, and no trained attention without protection from the forces actively training it the other way. That protection is the parent's job. Nobody else will do it. The schools will not. The church cannot. The broader culture is the one doing the harm. And when you fall short of this, which you will, go back to the principle we learned two chapters ago. Repair. Admit what you are doing. Tell your children you are trying to get better at it too. Let them see you struggle with it the way they struggle with it. Do not pretend you have it under control if you do not. The honesty will go further than the rules.

The next chapter is about the thing your child watched before they ever watched your phone, the thing they have been watching since the day they were born. Your marriage. And what it is teaching them about God, love, and the possibility of covenant. For now, teach them that attention is the currency of the soul. Then teach them, by your own example, to spend it on what is worthy.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Marriage as the First Classroom

Before your child watched you pray, they watched you love your spouse. Before they heard you read Scripture, they heard you argue. Before they saw you worship on Sunday morning, they saw you at the breakfast table, and they saw whether the person across from you was treated with tenderness or with indifference. Your marriage is the first classroom your child ever attended, and they enrolled the day they were born.

Most Christian parents keep marriage and parenting in separate rooms. Marriage is the relationship between the two adults. Parenting is what they do for the children. The two overlap at practical points — scheduling, discipline, money — but the marriage itself is rarely understood as a place where children are formed. It is. It is the primary one in the house, because it teaches the child, below the level of argument, what love is, what covenant looks like, and whether God's promises can be trusted.

I have watched this play out for two decades. The families where the children's faith proved most durable were not the ones with the best children's ministry involvement. They were the families where the marriage was alive. Where the parents were kind to each other in the kitchen. Where the father looked at the mother with something in his eyes that the children could see. Where conflict happened, but where repair happened too, and the children watched both. Those children grew up believing covenant is real, because they saw it. They grew up with an intuitive trust in the faithfulness of God, because the first covenant they observed, the marriage of their parents, was a covenant that held.

The reverse is also true. I have watched children grow up in homes where the marriage was cold. Not violent. Not dramatic. Cold. The parents functioned as coworkers. They managed the household, slept in the same bed, and lived in separate emotional worlds. Those children grew up with a theology of love that was functional, not intimate. God is useful. God provides. God manages the world. But God is

Your marriage is not a background condition to the work of forming your children. It is the foreground. It is the primary text the child is reading, and every other text — the Bible, the sermon, the devotional — is read against it. If the marriage says love is real, the other texts confirm it. If the marriage says love is a performance, they are undermined by it. You cannot teach your child about the love of God while living in a marriage that contradicts it. The child will believe the marriage.

THE INVISIBLE LESSONS

There are specific things a child learns from watching a marriage — the lessons no curriculum teaches and no program can replace.

The child learns about conflict. Every marriage has it. The question is what it teaches. Where conflict is avoided, the child learns that disagreement is dangerous, that peace means the absence of honest conversation, that love cannot survive a hard truth. Where conflict is explosive, the child learns that love is volatile, that anger is power, that words said in heat are normal, and that you never know when the safe person will become unsafe. Where conflict happens honestly and is repaired faithfully, the child learns something rare. That two people can disagree, can even hurt each other, and can come back together. That repair is real, that love is not the absence of conflict but the commitment to stay in the room. That is a theology. The theology of a God who does not abandon His people

I owe the argument something about my own marriage. Susanna and I have had seasons where it was not teaching our sons what we wanted it to teach. There was a year, not long ago, when ministry demands and exhaustion had pushed us into a functional partnership rather than an intimate marriage. We were efficient. We were not close. And one of our boys, the one with the eyes that miss nothing, said to Susanna one evening: you and Dad do not laugh together anymore. He was not criticizing. He was observing. And his observation was devastating in its accuracy. We had stopped laughing. We had stopped looking at each other with the thing the children needed to see. We had become coworkers in a household, and the household was running, but the marriage was not alive, and the children knew it.

That observation turned us. We decided, together, to invest in the marriage as a spiritual act on behalf of our children. Not because they needed to see a perfect marriage. Because they needed to see one that was being tended, where the adults were choosing each other, where the kindness was deliberate. We started dating again. Not as a formula. As a need. We started praying together again, as a couple — not in front of the children but for each other — because a shared prayer life between husband and wife creates a warmth in the home the children can feel even when they cannot name it.

The child learns about affection. Physical affection between a husband and wife, in front of the children, teaches the child that love is not abstract. It has a body. It is given and received. I kiss Susanna in the kitchen. I hold

The child learns about respect. How a husband speaks to his wife, and how a wife speaks to her husband, is one of the most formative things in a household. A husband who dismisses his wife, who corrects her in front of the children, who treats her opinions as less important than his own, is teaching his sons how to treat women and his daughters what to accept from men. A wife who belittles her husband, who rolls her eyes at his ideas, is teaching the same lessons in reverse. Children catalog every interaction. They are building their reference for what marriage looks like, and whatever is in it will feel normal to them, because it is what they grew up with.

The child learns about forgiveness. This may be the most important lesson of all. Your child needs to see you forgive your spouse. Not in general. Specifically. They need to hear you say, in the aftermath of a conflict they witnessed: I was wrong. I am sorry. Will you forgive me. And they need to hear the other person say: yes. That exchange, repeated over years, teaches the child more about the gospel than any sermon can. The gospel is the story of a God who forgives, and the child who has watched

COVENANT THE CHILD CAN SEE

Some of you are reading this in marriages that are not well. The marriage is strained. The affection is gone. The conflict is constant, or the silence is total. And you are reading with a growing weight, because you know what your marriage is teaching your children and you do not know how to change it.

Hear me. I am not writing this to add guilt. I am writing it to name the thing honestly, because naming it is the first step toward changing it. If your marriage is not teaching your children what you want it to teach, the answer is not to perform a better marriage in front of them. They will see through the performance. The answer is to actually tend the marriage. To get help. To go to a counselor. To talk to your pastor. To start the repair that has been deferred for years. That is not a distraction from raising your children. It is the work of raising your children, because the marriage is the first classroom and you cannot reform the classroom while the curriculum stays broken.

Consider what the marriage teaches about covenant. We live in a culture that treats commitment as provisional. You commit until you do not want to commit anymore. You stay until staying costs more than leaving. Children absorb that message from every direction. The marriage in the home is the counter-message. It is the place where the child sees two people who made a promise and are keeping it. Not because keeping it is easy. Not because every day is good. Because the promise is real. Because

When your child sees you choose your spouse on a hard day, choose to be kind when you are tired, choose to stay when staying is difficult, you are teaching them that covenant is not a contract. A contract has exit clauses. A covenant has steadfastness. And the God of the Bible is a covenant God. He does not exit. He does not abandon. Your marriage, kept in faithfulness over decades, is the child's first evidence that this is true.

*You cannot reform the classroom
while the curriculum stays broken.*

It is not too late to change what your marriage is teaching. Even if the children are older. Even if the damage has been done. A marriage that begins to heal in front of the children, that begins to warm after a cold season, teaches them something about restoration that changes the air in a home. That dead things can come alive. That cold things can be warmed. That broken covenants can be repaired. And if that is true in a marriage, maybe it is true with God. Maybe restoration is not a theory. Maybe it is the way God actually works. The children will believe it if they see it.

Tend your marriage. Not for the marriage alone. For the children who are watching it, learning from it, and building their theology of love from what they see in it every day.

If you are in a marriage that is alive, guard it. The forces working against a Christian marriage are relentless. Exhaustion, distraction, unresolved conflict, the slow drift of two people who stop choosing each other because the logistics of life have replaced the intimacy.

Make time for each other that is not about the children. Talk about something other than the schedule. Pray together, even when you do not feel like it. Confess to each other. Forgive each other. Touch each other. Laugh together. Your children need you to do these things, not because they are watching a performance, but because they are absorbing a reality. A marriage that is being tended teaches them what God's faithfulness looks like.

If you are in a marriage that is not alive, do not resign yourself to it. Talk to each other first. Not about the children. Not about the schedule. About what has gone cold between you and why. Many marriages die not from a single catastrophe but from a thousand small neglects. The conversation skipped because you were tired. The touch that stopped because the affection felt forced. The prayer you used to pray together that you stopped because it felt awkward after a fight you never resolved. Those neglects accumulate, and they eventually produce a marriage where two people share a house but not a life.

I have counseled couples who could not remember the last time they had a conversation that was not about logistics. When I asked what they talked about when they were dating, they both got quiet. They remembered. Their dreams. Their fears. Their faith. What they wanted their life to look like. What they believed about God. Those

The repair begins with a decision. Not a feeling. A decision. We are going to talk to each other again about things that matter. We are going to pray together again. We are going to touch each other with tenderness, even when it does not come naturally, because discipline precedes desire and the tenderness will follow the decision if we sustain it. That decision is not romantic. It is covenantal. And covenantal decisions are the ones that save marriages.

THE PASTOR'S MARRIAGE

I want to speak to the dynamic I have seen in ministry marriages, because I live inside it. The pastor's marriage carries a weight other marriages do not. Not because the pastor is more important. Because the pastor's marriage is more visible, more scrutinized, more subject to the demands of a community that does not always understand what it is asking. The pastor gives emotional energy to the congregation all week. They expect him to be available, present, steady. And the person who absorbs the cost of that expenditure is the spouse.

Susanna has told me, more than once, that she sometimes feels like she gets whatever is left over after the church has taken what it needs. She is not wrong. There have been seasons where I gave the best of my energy to the congregation and came home with the scraps. Where I was patient with church members and impatient with her.

If you are in ministry, hear me. Your marriage is not an obstacle to your ministry. Your marriage is your first ministry. If you are preaching about the love of God on Sunday and your spouse does not feel loved by you on Tuesday, something is broken, and it is not the sermon schedule. It is you. Fix the Tuesday before you preach the Sunday.

I have had to learn this the hard way. More than once. And each time, the lesson has been the same. The congregation can survive a week without my best. Susanna should not have to. The children should not have to. The household is the first call on my energy, and when I get that order wrong, everything else suffers, including the ministry I was prioritizing over the household.

A word about physical intimacy, because it matters to the argument even though most Christian parenting books leave it alone. Your children are not aware of the details of your physical relationship with your spouse. But they are aware of its effects. A marriage where physical intimacy is alive produces a different emotional climate than one where it has gone dormant. The warmth between the parents, the ease of touch, the look that passes between them in the kitchen — all of it is visible to the children even when the intimacy itself is private. The child does not know why the house feels warm. The child feels that it is warm. And that warmth is part of the formation

When physical intimacy dies in a marriage, it takes emotional warmth with it. The parents become roommates. The children feel the chill. I am not reducing marriage to the bedroom. I am saying the bedroom affects the kitchen, and the kitchen is where the children eat, and the meals they eat in a warm kitchen form them differently than the meals they eat in a cold one. Guard the whole marriage. Not the parts the children see. The whole thing. Because the children are formed by the whole thing, whether they can name what they sense or not.

Seek help. Talk to your pastor. Find a counselor. Read the books that have helped others. Not because a dead marriage is a personal failure, though it may involve confession. Because the children in your house are building their theology of love from what they see, and what they see right now is not what you want them to carry. The repair of a marriage, done in front of children over months and years, teaches them that dead things can be raised. That is a resurrection theology. It is the most Christian thing a married couple can do.

WHEN THE MARRIAGE HAS ENDED

And if your marriage has ended, through death or divorce, hear this. The formation of your children is not over. The household looks different now. The catechism has changed. But the four channels are still running. What you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in. Those channels are still forming your children. And the way you handle the grief, the transition, the rebuilding, is itself formation.

A parent who grieves honestly, who refuses to become

Let me speak directly to the parent walking through divorce, because the formation challenges are particular. Your children are watching how you treat their other parent. Whether you speak with bitterness or with restraint. Whether you use them as messengers or as weapons or as people. Whether the faith you profess survives the worst thing that has happened to your family.

I have counseled parents who handled divorce in ways that devastated their children's faith. Not through the divorce itself. Through the behavior during and after it. The parent who badmouthed the other parent in front of the children. The parent who used the children as a bargaining chip. The parent so consumed by their own pain that the children's pain became invisible. In each case, the child's theology of love, covenant, and faithfulness was damaged not by the divorce but by the conduct of the parents during it.

I have also counseled parents who handled it in ways that preserved and even deepened their children's faith. The parent who said, your father and I could not make our marriage work, and that is a grief I carry, but he is still your father and I will not speak against him in this house. The parent who said, I am angry and I am hurt, and I am bringing those things to God because they are too big to carry alone. The parent who prioritized the children's stability over their own need to process publicly. Those parents taught their children something about grace

If you are in that situation, hear me. Your conduct during and after the divorce is one of the most significant formation moments in your children's lives. You did not choose the situation. You can choose the conduct. And it will form your children's understanding of what it means to follow Jesus when everything falls apart. Choose well. Not perfectly. Well. With as much grace and restraint and honesty as you can gather, and with the confidence that God is forming your children through this, even through this, if you will let Him.



Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her.

— EPHESIANS 5:25

The next chapter is for the parents of teenagers, because the teenage years are the season when everything we have discussed goes underground, and the parent must learn an entirely different posture.

CHAPTER NINE

The Teenage Years, When Formation Goes Underground

There is a day that comes for every parent, and you will not see it coming. The child who told you everything stops telling you things. The child who crawled into your lap during family worship sits across the room and says nothing. The child who asked you about God at bedtime now reaches for the earbuds the moment the car door shuts. The door that was open is closing, and you did not hear it happen. You only noticed the silence.

Name it for what it is. The teenage years are the season when formation goes underground. Everything you built in the first twelve or thirteen years does not vanish. It goes below the surface. The child who was open becomes private. The child who was eager becomes skeptical. The child who was compliant becomes confrontational, or withdrawn. And the parent, used to a certain kind of

This is normal. It is also agonizing, because from where the parent stands it feels like loss. It feels like drift. It feels like the work has stopped, or worse, come undone. So the parent panics, and the panic runs in one of two directions. The parent grips harder — more control, more surveillance, more pressure to perform the old closeness. Or the parent withdraws, reading the distance as rejection, and answers distance with distance.

Both responses wound the thing they mean to protect. Grip harder and you produce an adolescent who either submits in resentment or rebels in desperation. Withdraw and you produce an adolescent who reads your withdrawal as proof that his pulling away was wrong, that your love was conditional on his accessibility. Neither road ends at a young adult with a mature faith. Both end at a young adult who learned, in the most critical years of his identity, that his parent could not handle who he was becoming.

THE TEST HAS TO HAPPEN WHERE YOU CANNOT SEE IT

Reframe it. The adolescent pulling away is not the end of formation. It is the most critical phase of it. Everything planted in the first twelve years is now being tested — by the child, by the culture, by the child's own doubt and desire. And the test cannot happen under the parent's supervision. That is the terrible truth. The faith formed in

For the first twelve years, the child's faith was held inside yours. He believed because you believed. He prayed because you prayed. He went to church because you took him. His faith was, in a real sense, your faith, borrowed. During adolescence he has to decide whether to keep it — whether the faith he inherited is the faith he will carry. That decision cannot be made under supervision. It can only be made in the privacy of his own mind and heart. Your job, in this phase, is not to control the decision. It is to be present enough that he knows there is a safe place to land, whatever the decision turns out to be.

I have five sons. Some have already been through this. Others are in it now. From the inside of it I can tell you that nothing in my pastoral training prepared me for watching my own child work out his faith in a way I could not direct. I could preach about it. I could counsel other parents through it. But when it was my son closing the bedroom door, my son answering in monosyllables, my son showing no flicker of interest in the things that used to light him up, I felt the same fear every parent feels. And I had to do the thing I had counseled others to do, which was keep my hands open instead of clenched.

WHAT THE ADOLESCENT BRAIN IS ACTUALLY DOING

The neuroscience matters here, so let me name it plainly. The teenage brain is undergoing a massive reorganization. The prefrontal cortex — executive function, long-term planning, impulse control, the capacity to hold competing ideas in tension — is not fully developed until the mid-

This is why teenagers are so confusing to their parents. The teenager feels with the intensity of an adult and processes with the capacity of a brain still being built. He is not choosing to be irrational. His brain is in a construction zone. And the faith he is weighing is being weighed by a brain that runs ideas through the emotional centers first. His experience of faith is heavily mediated by feeling. If God feels distant, God is distant. If prayer feels empty, prayer is meaningless. If church feels boring, church has nothing for him. The parent who tries to argue a teenager out of his feelings with logic is arguing against a brain not yet wired to receive the argument.

This does not mean you abandon logic. It means you lead with relationship. The adolescent brain is wired for relationship above nearly everything. Peer bonds become paramount. But the parental bond does not disappear; it goes underground like everything else. The teenager who will not talk to you at the dinner table is still tracking whether you are present. He is tracking whether you notice his absence, whether you care enough to keep trying when he gives you nothing back. He is watching from behind the closed door to see if you are still there.

WHAT I HAVE LEARNED, AT COST

Here is what fifteen years of ministry and five sons have taught me about parenting a teenager in the faith. None of

Reduce the number of hills you will die on. When children are small, the parent draws every boundary. When they are teenagers, you must decide which boundaries are essential and which are negotiable. Fight over everything — hair, music, friends, curfew, phone, chores, clothing, language, church attendance — and you will lose the teenager entirely, because he will conclude you care more about control than about him. Hold the line on safety, on moral integrity, on respect in the house. Bend on the rest. The teenager with some agency, some room to make choices you would not make, is a teenager learning to be a person. That learning is messy. It is also the point.

Stay in the room. When he pushes you away, stay in the room — not physically, because he needs the physical space, but relationally. Keep asking about his day when all you get is one word back. Keep inviting him to things when he keeps saying no. Keep telling him you love him when he rolls his eyes. Keep making his favorite meal. Keep being interested in what interests him, even when his interests confuse or concern you. The parent who refuses to withdraw when the teenager withdraws is the parent the teenager comes back to when the phase shifts. And it will shift. It always does. The parent who was still there when it shifts stands in a wholly different position than the parent who left.

Answer the questions he is not asking out loud. Teenagers ask theological questions with their behavior long before they ask them with their words. The one who refuses church is asking whether this faith is real or merely forced. The one who dates someone you disapprove of is asking whether you will love him if he

*They are not rebellions. They are
questions wearing the clothing of
rebellion.*

Let him see your faith in its adult complexity. To a small child you give faith in simple terms: God loves you, Jesus died for you, the Bible is true. To a teenager those terms are no longer enough. He needs to see that faith has an adult version — that it can hold doubt, that it has wrestled hard questions, that it has survived suffering, that it is not naive. If the only faith he has ever seen is the children's version, he will discard it, because he is no longer a child. So give him the adult version. Tell him about the hard parts. Tell him about the time you nearly lost it. Tell him about the questions you still carry, the books that unsettled you, the arguments that made you think. Show him that faith is not something you outgrow. It grows with you, into the hardest parts of an adult life.

And pray more than you lecture. In the teenage years your primary spiritual work for the child shifts from instruction to intercession. You have said what you needed

IF YOU THINK YOU STARTED TOO LATE

Many parents of teenagers are terrified they began too late. They did not do the work in the early years. They never built the household catechism. They outsourced to the church, and now the teenager is pulling away and there is little foundation to stand on. If that is you, let me be honest. It is harder. Starting at fourteen is harder than starting at four. But it is not impossible, because God is not bound by your timeline. The parent who starts being real with a teenager now — honest about his own failures, asking instead of lecturing, present instead of controlling — can rebuild the relationship into the bridge the teenager crosses when he is ready.

The teenage years are not the years you lose your child. They are the years your child decides whether to keep what you gave him. Your role is not to force the decision. It is to be the kind of person he wants to come back to once the decision is made. That is enough. It will not feel like enough. It is.

One of my older sons went through a season, around fifteen, when he stopped wanting to go to church. He announced no departure from the faith. He gave no speech. He started saying he was tired on Sunday mornings, started finding reasons to stay home. He was not hostile. He was distant. And I felt the fear rise in me, the same fear I had counseled dozens of other parents through.

My first instinct was to mandate it. He lives under my roof; he will go to church. That instinct came from fear, not wisdom. Susanna and I talked. We prayed. We chose a different way. We told him church mattered to our family and that we wanted him there. We also told him we would not force him, because forced worship is not worship. If he chose to stay home on a given Sunday, that was his call, and we would love him the same either way. And we asked him to tell us honestly what was going on.

He told us. Church felt boring. The sermons did not connect to his life. He felt like he was going through motions. He was not rejecting God. He was rejecting the experience as he was having it — and those are different things. Because we listened instead of reacting, we learned something we would never have learned if we had forced him into the car.

So we made changes. I started talking with him after the service about the sermon, not as a quiz but as a conversation. I asked what he disagreed with. I asked what confused him. I let him push back on things I had said from the pulpit. That was uncomfortable for me. It was essential for him. Over several months he came back — not

Not every story ends that way. Some teenagers pull away and stay away a long time. Some never come back to church even if they come back to God. The point of the story is not the outcome. The point is the posture. The parent who listens, who does not panic, who keeps the relationship above the compliance, gives the teenager the best chance of owning the faith for himself. Whether he takes that chance is not in your hands. The posture is.

WHEN IT IS NOT A PHASE

One word for the parent whose teenager is not merely questioning the faith but is in a genuinely dark place — using substances, in a destructive relationship, harming himself, speaking of hopelessness. That is not the situation I have been describing. That situation calls for intervention, not patience. If your teenager is in danger, get help. Talk to a counselor. Talk to your pastor. Do not wait for the phase to pass, because some phases do not pass on their own.

The parent who steps into a crisis, who says I love you too much to watch this happen, is not violating his teenager's autonomy. He is exercising parental love at its highest and most costly. Do not confuse the patience I described for ordinary adolescence with passivity in the face of real danger. They are not the same thing.

THE FRIENDS, THE OTHER ADULTS, THE END OF THE TUNNEL

That does not mean you choose his friends for him; that level of control breeds rebellion, not formation. It means you should know who they are. Invite them over. Feed them. Talk to them. Watch how your child acts around them, because a teenager who becomes a different person in the presence of certain friends is a teenager whose formation is being pulled somewhere you need to understand. I have made it our practice to make our home the gathering place — my sons' friends in our house rather than my sons in houses I do not know. This is not surveillance. It is hospitality with a purpose. When the friends are here, I can hear the conversations and see whether they bring out the best in my son or something else. And my son, watching me be kind to his friends, does not feel policed. He feels his world is welcome in ours. There have been friendships that concerned me. I did not forbid them. I named what I saw, asked him what he thought, and trusted him with the decision while making clear I was watching because I loved him, not because I doubted him. In one case my son told me I was wrong about a friend, and he was right. I had misjudged. I told him so and thanked him for helping me see it.

Your teenager also needs adults in his life who are not you — adults he respects, who share your faith, whom he can talk to when he cannot talk to you. This is not a failure of your parenting. It is a feature of adolescent

And the teenage years will end. I say this to the parent in the middle of them who cannot see the end. The withdrawal will ease. The resistance will soften. The door that is closed will open again — not on your timeline, on his, but it will open. The parent who was still standing at the door when it opens, who did not walk away, who did not retaliate, who did not answer the teenager's distance with his own, will be the one the young adult comes back to. I have watched it happen enough times to say it with confidence. The parents who stay, who keep loving and praying and keeping the relationship above the rules, see their children come back. Not always to church. Not always on the parent's terms. But back. Back to relationship. Back to conversation. Back to the faith they tested and found, after testing it, to be real.

The teenage years are a tunnel. It is dark in the tunnel, and the parent cannot see where it goes. But there is light at the far end, and the parent who keeps walking, keeps

Trust the process — not the therapeutic slogan, the actual theological one. God is at work in your teenager. The Holy Spirit is pursuing him with a persistence that exceeds your own. Your job is not to be the Holy Spirit. Your job is to stay close enough that when the Spirit does His work, your teenager has someone safe to tell about it.



Train up a child in the way he should go; even when he is old he will not depart from it.

— PROVERBS 22:6

The next chapter is for the fathers, because everything I have described in these last several chapters depends, in a particular way, on the presence and posture of the man in the house.

CHAPTER TEN

Fathers, Presence, and the Weight of Blessing

I grew up without a father. I have said it once already in this book, and I will say it again before the end, because it is the place everything in me starts. I know what absence does to a boy. I have watched it do its slow work in the lives of the men I have pastored for twenty years. And I know something the church seems to have forgotten: the conversation about Christian fatherhood has gotten so sentimental that it no longer lands on the men who most need it. So this chapter will be blunt. If you are a father, I am asking you to stand inside the indictment with me. I am already in it.

Name it plainly. American Christian fatherhood has become largely ornamental. In a great many professing Christian homes, the father is physically present and spiritually peripheral. He provides. He appears for the big

This kind of absence has a signature. Ask a child in a Christian home who prays for them by name at night. Where the mother does it, God bless her, she is often doing it alone. Ask who reads Scripture with them. Often the mother. Ask who walks them through the hard conversations — purpose, sin, sex, failure, calling. Often the mother, or no one. Ask who blesses them when they leave the house. Often no one. The father is at work, or on his phone, or decompressing, or simply not thinking about it. He is not hostile to the faith. He is just not carrying the weight.

THE WEIGHT A FATHER CARRIES

The weight is the word. The biblical picture of a father is a man who carries weight on behalf of his household. The weight of provision, yes. But also the weight of prayer, of blessing, of correction delivered in love. The weight of deciding, often, which direction the household will face. The weight of being the first one to repent when he has been wrong. The weight of being home when his people need him home. A father who carries only the economic weight is not carrying the biblical weight. A father who carries the biblical weight is doing something his children are shaped by for life, whether or not they can name it at the time.

I have a theory about why so many men carry only the lighter weight, and it goes deeper than laziness. Most

The Bible's understanding of fatherhood is not cultural. It is covenantal. The father represents something that cannot be outsourced. However imperfectly, he represents the Fatherhood of God to his children. He is the first picture they get of what a Father is like. That is an enormous thing to lay on a man, and it is meant to be. It is meant to drive him to his knees. It is meant to send him to the actual Father, daily, for the grace he needs to represent Him at all. A Christian father is not a man who has mastered the old patriarchal script. He is a man who has become small enough before God to be used as a window — the window through which his children get their first glimpse of the Father's face.

This is why the stakes are not abstract. If the father is angry, the children will struggle for decades to believe God is not angry. If the father is absent, they will struggle to believe God is not absent. If the father is forever disappointed, they will carry the quiet sense that they have disappointed God. Theology in the head competes with

THE HOLLOW PLACE

A man in my congregation came to me about three years ago. He was in his late thirties, with two sons, eight and six. He had been raised in a Christian home by a father who was doctrinally precise and emotionally unavailable — a man who could explain substitutionary atonement and had never told his son he loved him. The man in my office was carrying a wound he had never named, and it was leaking into his own fathering. He was repeating the pattern. He knew it. He did not know how to stop.

I asked him when he had last blessed his sons by name. He looked at me as though I were speaking a foreign language. So I explained. Lay your hand on your son's head. Tell him who he is. Tell him who God is making him. Speak a future over him. Use the Aaronic blessing if you do not have your own words yet. He said he had never done it. He said his father had never done it. And then he started crying, because he understood, in that moment, that the hollow place inside him was the place where a father's blessing was supposed to be.

He went home that night and blessed his eight-year-old for the first time. He told me later that the boy looked up at him with wide eyes and said, Dad, do that again. The child was hungry for it. He did not know what it was called. He only knew it was the thing his soul had been waiting for.

A generation of men is walking

This is why a Christian father must take his own formation seriously. You cannot offer your children a God you do not know. You cannot represent a Father whose face you rarely see. Your children will absorb your actual relationship with God, not the one you wish you had. If that relationship is thin, their inheritance is a thin God. If it is alive, their inheritance is a living one. This is the most important pastoral work any man ever does, and the work he is usually least equipped for, because the church has rarely disciplined men to do it and the culture has given him no categories beyond breadwinner and occasional disciplinarian.

THREE THINGS, STARTING THIS WEEK

Let me be practical. There are three things a father can begin this week that change the spiritual climate of a home more than almost anything else I can name.

The first is to bless your children by name, out loud, regularly. Not as a performance. As a pattern. Lay your hand on the child's head and speak words over them. You are my son. I love you. I am proud of the way God is building you. The oldest words for it are the best ones, and you can borrow them until your own arrive:

– NUMBERS 6:24-26

Some of you are reading that and finding it strange, even foreign. I understand. The first time I did it with one of my sons, I was self-conscious. I kept doing it anyway. It is now one of the most load-bearing practices in my home. My sons expect it. They ask for it when I forget. There is something in a child designed to receive a father's blessing, and it starves without it. Starving is not too strong a word. Bless them now, while they are small, and keep blessing them when they are grown.

The second is to pray with your children, out loud, often. Not for them. With them. Let them hear you thank God for specific things by name. Let them hear you ask for mercy when you were wrong. Let them hear you intercede for people outside the family, including the people who are hard for you to love. Let them hear you carry your worries to God rather than to the television. Prayer practiced in front of children catechizes them in what God is for and how He is to be approached. You cannot outsource this to a grace before meals that nobody means. Your children should hear you pray often enough that they begin to pray the same way when you are not in the room. That is the mark.

The third is to repent in front of your children. This one is harder, and most men avoid it. They believe authority in the home is held by never showing weakness. That is a cultural script, not a Christian one. A father who is never

I have had to do this many times — more than I would like. I have snapped at my sons. I have been withdrawn when I should have been present. I have come home from ministry with nothing left and spent the nothing on the people I most love. Every time I have gone back, admitted it, asked forgiveness, and prayed with the child about it, the relationship has strengthened rather than weakened. Children do not need an unimpeachable father. They need an honest one — a father who is being sanctified in front of them, not one pretending he has arrived.

SONS, DAUGHTERS, AND THE FIRST WORD

To fathers of sons: your boys are watching you to learn what a man is. The culture will not tell them. The schools often will not. The internet will offer them a thousand broken versions of manhood and hope to leave them either ashamed or bitter. You get the first word. Speak it.

A man is a servant of God who carries weight for the sake of others. A man is not afraid to kneel before God. He is not afraid to apologize. He is strong enough to be gentle. He works hard, protects what God has put under his care,

To fathers of daughters: your daughters are watching you to learn what a man is like, and to learn how they should expect to be treated by one. The way you love their mother is a template. The way you speak to her is a template. The way you listen, or do not, is a template. One day a man will come to win her, and whether she can tell a true one from a false one will have been shaped, in large part, by you. Give her so much evidence of what love looks like that she can spot the counterfeit at a hundred yards.

THE MINISTRY FATHER, AND THE DISCIPLINE OF PRESENCE

I want to add something I have not often seen in books on fatherhood, because I know it from the inside. The ministry father gives his best hours, his best energy, his best emotional availability to the congregation. He has been present all day, for other people's families. He comes home spent, with nothing left for his own. His wife sees it. His children see it. They learn that other people's needs come first. That God's work, as the church represents it, matters more than God's work in this home. That the pastor's family is the sacrifice the pastor makes for the ministry.

That is a lie, and it has destroyed more pastoral families than I can count. I have been in this sin. There were seasons when I gave my church my best and gave my family my empty, and the result was predictable. My sons pulled away — not from God, from me. They had learned

But the deeper problem is not unique to pastors. It belongs to every father who is here but not present. You come home every evening. You eat at the table. You attend the events. And your mind is somewhere else, your phone in your hand, your work following you home in your head where you cannot set it down. You are a body in a chair, and your children have learned to tell the difference between a father who is in the room and a father who is with them.

Presence is not proximity. I can sit three feet from my son and be a thousand miles away — at the dinner table, turning over a sermon or a budget meeting or a hard phone call, while he tells me about his day and feels the distance as plainly as if I had left. He stops talking. He looks down at his plate. He learns that his voice is not interesting enough to hold his father's attention, and that lesson, absorbed over a thousand dinners, forms something in him no bedtime blessing can undo.

The discipline of presence is one of the hardest disciplines of fatherhood. It asks you to set things down —

TO THE MAN WHO HAD NO FATHER

I have saved a word for last, and it is for the men like me — the men who did not have a father, or had one whose presence wounded them. Many of you are feeling the old grief as you read. I know it. I have lived in it. And I know the particular difficulty it creates when you sit down to form children of your own.

When you had no model, you are building the plane while flying it. There is no template, no voice in your memory that says, this is what a good father sounds like. There is a silence where that voice should be, and the silence breeds two opposite errors. Either you try too hard, becoming an overwhelming presence that smothers rather than forms. Or you withdraw, afraid you will repeat patterns you cannot even name, because the patterns are absences rather than actions — and how do you keep

I have lived in both errors. In the early years I compensated. I was at every game, every practice, every school event, present in body to a degree that exhausted me, because I was terrified of being absent the way my father was absent. And my presence, driven by fear instead of love, had an edge my sons could feel. Fear-driven presence is a form of control. It looks like devotion and feels like surveillance. Then I swung the other way and pulled back, telling myself I was giving them space when I was really protecting myself from an intensity of fatherhood I did not know how to regulate. Children always feel the difference between a father who gives them room and a father who is retreating.

The correction came, as it often does, through my wife. Susanna sat me down one evening and said the thing that changed the course of my fathering. You are either trying to be the father you did not have, she said, or running from the fear that you will fail the way he failed. Neither of those is you. Find the father God made you to be. It took me years to unwrap it, but the core was simple and hard. I could not parent from a wound. I had to parent from a healed place. And healing the father wound meant taking the wound to God rather than to my children. My sons are not responsible for healing my father's absence. God is. As He has done that healing, slowly, across years, the fathering that comes out of me has grown less driven by fear and more rooted in love.

So if you are a father without a father, hear me. You are not disqualified. You are not destined to repeat what was done to you, or what was never done. But the wound will define your fathering if you leave it untreated, because

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Single Parents, Blended Families, and the God Who Holds

I have written the last several chapters with one household in mind. Two parents, married, both present, both professing faith. That is the picture most Christian parenting books assume, and I have assumed it too, because it is the household I live in and the one I know best. But if I stop there, I fail a great many of the people reading this. Many of you are not in that picture. And the implication, rarely stated but always felt, is that a household which does not match the picture has children whose formation is compromised beyond repair.

That implication is a lie, and it needs to be named as one. Plainly, so that the parent reading this in a house that does not match the picture can hear what follows without the lie in the way.

I want to speak directly to that. It is half true and entirely unhelpful.

The half that is true is this. Two believing parents create a formation environment with structural advantages. More presence. More modeling. More reinforcement. A child who watches a mother and a father both walk with God has two windows into the character of God. That is real, and I will not pretend otherwise.

The half that is a lie is the leap from advantage to impossibility. The absence of one parent does not make formation impossible. The God who promises to be Father to the fatherless, who keeps particular watch over the widow and the orphan, has not left the single parent's household without resources. He promised to fill what is missing, and He meant it. I have watched Him do it. I have watched single mothers raise children whose faith went the distance. I have watched single fathers carry a weight that would have flattened most people and produce homes where Christ was more visible, not less, because the dependence on God was more real. The parent clinging to

A DIFFERENT HOUSEHOLD, NOT A BROKEN ONE

The single-parent home is not a damaged copy of the two-parent home. It is a different household, with different challenges and different graces. The formation principles in this book apply to it without exception. The four channels of the household catechism still run: what you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in. They run in a single-parent home exactly as they run anywhere else. The child is still formed by proximity to the parent's actual life with God. The parent's faith is still the primary curriculum.

What changes is the weight. The single parent carries more of it. The economic weight, the emotional weight, the logistical weight, the spiritual weight, all of it, and carries it without the partner who was supposed to share the load. That weight is real. I will not spiritualize it into something lighter than it is. Some days it is crushing. Some weeks. Some years.

Which is where the church is supposed to come in. The church is meant to be the extended family the single-parent household needs, the additional believing adults the child needs, the uncles and aunts and mentors the home cannot supply on its own. This is not a program. It is the body of Christ working as the body of Christ. A single mother in a church that knows her name, that feeds her

Let me be direct with the church for a moment. A congregation that praises the family and offers no concrete support to single parents is not a family church. It is a church for a certain kind of family, and the single parent feels the difference. She walks into the mother-daughter event and sits alone. He comes to the men's retreat and never hears his situation named. Their children sit in the youth group and no one has asked whether they have a believing adult who is not their surviving parent. The church has to do better, not out of pity, but out of the theology it already confesses. If the body has members carrying more than they can carry alone, the body bears the burden with them. That is not optional. That is Galatians 6.

FORMATION IN A BLENDED FAMILY

The blended family has its own set of formation challenges, different from the single-parent home and almost never addressed in Christian parenting literature. It is a household where children are being formed by adults who do not all share the same history. The stepparent enters mid-story. The child has a past with a biological parent that the stepparent was never part of, loyalties that compete, grief over the loss of the original family. No matter how loving the new family is, its presence is a standing reminder of what was lost.

What I have seen work is a posture of presence without presumption. The stepparent is present. Consistent. Kind. They do not force the relationship. They let it grow at the child's pace, not the adult's. The biological parent supports the stepparent's authority in age-appropriate ways without requiring the child to feel about the stepparent the way they feel about their own. The household says openly that this family has a complex history, and that the complexity is not a failure. It is a reality God is present in.

The formation principles still apply. The household still has a catechism. What it praises, what it worries about, what it repeats, what it rests in. The added complication is that the child may be absorbing two catechisms, one from each home, and the two may contradict. A child who spends weekdays in a home where Christ is the center and weekends in a home where Christ is irrelevant is receiving a divided inheritance. That is painful. It is also not fatal. The home where Christ is the center has something the other home does not, the presence and power of the Holy Spirit, and the Spirit is not bound by a custody arrangement.

So hear this, blended-family parent. You are not at a

THE COSTLY HOPE

The hope in this chapter is for every parent whose household does not match the picture on the cover of the parenting book. God is not limited by your family structure. He is not limited by your marital status, the complexity of your custody arrangement, your ex-spouse's hostility to the faith, your age, your energy, your resources, or your mistakes. He is limited by nothing. He placed your children in your care, in this household, in this configuration, and He intends to use you to form them. Not despite the difficulty. Through it.

*Let them see a faith that is not
decorative but necessary. The lifeline
of the household that has nothing else
to hold onto.*

A PRACTICAL WORD FOR SINGLE PARENTS

You need practical words more than theological ones. You already know God is with you. What you need is help.

First, accept help. Many single parents resist it, feeling they should manage alone, feeling that to accept help is to admit defeat. It is not defeat. It is wisdom. God designed the body of Christ to share burdens. You are not failing when you let someone watch your children so you can rest, when you ask another family to bring your son on their camping trip, when you let the grandmother take the kids for a weekend so you can breathe. You are cooperating with the design.

Second, identify the believing adults your children need. Your child needs role models beyond you. If you are a single mother, your son needs godly men in his life. Not a replacement father, a presence. A man who can take him fishing, teach him to change a tire, be the male image of God the household does not currently hold. If you are a single father, your daughter needs godly women, not a replacement mother, but women who can speak into her life in the ways only women can. Look for these people in your church. Ask your pastor to help you find them. If your church cannot provide them, find a church that can. Your children's formation depends partly on the community around them, and building that community is among the most important things you can do.

Fourth, tell your children the truth about your household, at a level they can receive. Children in single-parent homes carry unspoken questions. Why is my family different. Is something wrong with us. Did I cause this. Answer those questions before the child has to ask. Tell them your family looks different and that God is in this family completely. Tell them the absence of one parent is not the absence of God's provision. Tell them you are doing this together, and that together includes God. Children can carry more truth than we think. What they cannot carry is silence. Silence breeds shame. Truth, spoken with love, breeds security.

THE MOTHER WHO TAUGHT ME THE PRINCIPLE

There is a single mother in my church who has taught me more about formation than most two-parent families I know. She was divorced when her children were young. The circumstances were painful, and she did not choose them. She found herself raising three children on a teacher's salary, in a small apartment, with no family

What she did was this. She built a household catechism with the materials she had. She could not afford the Christian school, the retreats, the summer camps. What she could afford was time, and she spent it lavishly. Every evening she sat at the table and asked her children about their day, not casually but with attention. She prayed with them before bed, not for sixty seconds but for ten minutes, naming each child's specific concerns. She read the Bible to them, not from a curriculum but from wherever she happened to be reading herself, and she told them what it meant to her, in plain language, her own struggles included.

Her children are in their twenties now. All three are walking with Jesus. All three credit their mother's faith, not the church's programs, as the reason they believe. One of them told me the most formative thing about his childhood was hearing his mother pray. She prayed, he said, like she was talking to someone who was actually in the room. He believed God was real because his mother so clearly believed God was real, and her belief was neither inherited nor performed. It was forged. In the fire of raising three children alone while trusting a God she could not see to hold what she could not carry.



Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ.

— GALATIANS 6:2

That woman's household was not the model. It was the principle. And the principle worked because the presence was real.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Grandparents and the Long Memory of Faith

Most parents read the seventy-eighth psalm as a parenting verse. Most grandparents have never been told it is about them. Listen to how far it reaches:

We will tell the next generation the praiseworthy deeds of the Lord, his power, and the wonders he has done. He commanded our ancestors to teach their children, so the next generation would know them, even the children yet to be born, and they in turn would tell their children.

— PSALM 78:4-6

Count the generations. Ancestors. Their children. The next generation. Children yet to be born. Their children. Five. The psalmist is not describing a one-generation project. He is describing a relay, and a relay depends on every runner, not only the parents. It depends on the

The church has largely sidelined the grandparents from this conversation. Walk the parenting shelf at the bookstore and you will find books for parents of toddlers, parents of teenagers, parents of prodigals. You will find almost nothing for grandparents. That is strange, because a grandparent is one of the most formative presences in a child's life, and the absence is a loss the church has never bothered to measure.

WHAT GRANDPARENTS CARRY

Grandparents carry something parents do not have. Not schedule time. Deep time. The memory of decades. The evidence of God's faithfulness over a span of years the child's own parents have not yet lived.

A grandmother who has walked with God for fifty years carries fifty years of answered prayer, fifty years of sustained faith, fifty years of watching God work in rooms that seemed past hope. That memory is not sentimental. It is evidentiary. It is the testimony of a life lived long enough to confirm what Scripture promises. A child who hears it, from someone they trust, in an ordinary conversation, receives what no curriculum can hand them.

I think about my own congregation. The most formative people in the lives of the young families are not the young families' peers. They are the older saints. The woman in her seventies who has buried a husband, survived cancer, raised four children, and still weeps when she sings How Great Thou Art. The man in his eighties who fought in a

The grandparent's role is not supplementary. It is essential, because it fills the one gap a parent cannot fill: the gap between claimed faith and proven faith. A parent can tell a child that God is faithful. A grandparent can tell a child that God has been faithful for sixty years, here is the specific evidence, I bet my life on it, I am still here, and He is still good. The child needs both. But the grandparent's testimony carries a weight the parent's claim has not yet earned, because the grandparent has lived long enough to prove it.

FOUR THINGS ONLY A GRANDPARENT CAN GIVE

Let me be specific about what a grandparent can do that no one else in the child's life can. There are four, and they are not interchangeable. Each one does something the others cannot.

The first is story. Every family has a faith story, and in many families that story is dying in silence. The grandparent knows how the family came to faith. They know who prayed, who sacrificed, what the hard years cost, which prayers were answered and which miracles were small and which were not. That story is the child's inheritance. It is the narrative in which the child's own faith makes sense. A child who knows their grandmother came to Christ as a teenager in a small church in Alabama, that their grandfather came home from a war and built a

So tell it. At the dinner table, at Thanksgiving, in the car, while making cookies, while walking. Tell it when the grandchild opens the door with a question, and tell it when they do not, because sometimes the story is the invitation they did not know they needed. The informality makes it more real, not less. The child who hears a conversion story over a bowl of ice cream has been handed something that will surface, years later, at the exact moment they need it.

The second is prayer. A parent's prayer is urgent, shaped by the daily crisis of the formation project. A grandparent's prayer is long. The grandparent has learned across decades that God works slowly, that unanswered prayer is not unanswered, that years of intercession bear fruit on no human timeline. The one who prays for a grandchild by name, daily, for years, is laying a foundation the child will not understand until adulthood. Some of the most striking conversions I have witnessed were traced back, by the convert, to a grandmother who prayed.

Monica prayed for Augustine for decades. He was brilliant, rebellious, dissolute, lost. She prayed. She wept. She followed him across the Mediterranean. She prayed more. He came home. The greatest theologian in the history of the Western church was a grandmother's prayer project. Do not tell me prayer does not work. It works on a timeline longer than ours.

The third is stability. There are seasons when the parents are overwhelmed — illness, money, a marriage under strain, a job lost, a ministry burning down. The children feel the ground shift. They feel the parent's fear. A grandparent who is present can be the ground that does not shift, the steady hand, the calm voice, the reminder that this family has come through hard things before and God carried them. A child who has a grandparent as an anchor in a storm learns that faith does not depend on circumstances. It depends on God. And God does not move.

The fourth is love without the weight of the parenting role. The parent must enforce the rules and make the hard calls. The grandparent gets to love without agenda, to delight in the child rather than shape him, to be present without the pressure of the project. A child who has an adult who loves him that way, who is enjoyed rather than managed, celebrated rather than corrected, welcomed without having to perform, has a felt picture of the unconditional love of God that the parent, who must also discipline, cannot always provide. That delight is not indulgence. It is theology. It forms the child's capacity to receive the love of God.

Some of you feel sidelined. You feel the young parents do not want your input, that the culture has told you your season is over, that you do not understand the world your grandchildren are growing up in and therefore have nothing to offer them.

None of it is true. You have a life. You have testimony, prayer, presence. You have patience the young parents lack because they have not lived long enough to learn it, and perspective they lack because they are still inside what you can see from a distance. All of it is formative. All of it is needed.

So do not wait for an invitation. Offer yourself. Call them. Write them letters — actual letters, on paper, that they can hold and keep and read again when they are thirty and you are gone. Tell them what you believe and why. Tell them what God has done in your life and what you pray for them. Tell them the specific things you see in them that remind you of His work. Do not assume they know. Tell them.

Many of you carry a harder tension, between wanting to guide and not wanting to overstep. You see your grandchild raised in a way you would not have chosen, and you face the choice: speak up and risk the relationship, or stay silent and carry the worry. There is no formula. But here is a principle. Your primary gift is presence, not correction. If you must choose between being right and being present, choose presence. A grandchild who has you, who knows you love him, who has heard your testimony and been prayed for by name, has a resource he can draw on later, even if the parenting you disagreed with

The exception is moral or physical danger. If you see genuine harm, you speak — clearly, and with love. But most of parenting is gray, and in the gray your gift is patience, prayer, and presence. Not control.

WHEN THE STORY IS MISSING, AND WHEN IT IS BROKEN

I think about my own sons and the fact that they do not have grandparents who can tell them stories of multigenerational faith. My mother came to faith later in life.

The long arc of generational faithfulness, the kind where a grandparent can say, my grandmother prayed for me before I was born, and her mother prayed for her, and now I pray for you — that arc is not something we can give our sons. It is something I grieve, quietly, because I know the power of that kind of story and I know my sons do not have it. If you can tell that story, you are carrying something rare. Do not keep it to yourself. Tell it at Thanksgiving and tell it on ordinary Tuesdays when you are babysitting. The child will not remember every detail. He will remember that his grandparent had a story with God, and that he is part of it.

I want to speak to the grandparent who is raising grandchildren. There are more of you than anyone counts. You stepped in when the parents could not or would not. You are raising children at the age you thought you would rest. You are tired and afraid you are not enough, and you wonder whether the gap between your generation and

And I want to speak to the grandparent estranged from grandchildren. A son or a daughter has pulled away. The relationship is broken. You are not permitted into their lives the way you long to be, and the grief of that is among the most painful things a person can carry. I cannot fix it in a chapter. I can tell you this: pray anyway. Your prayers are not restricted by geography or distance. Write the letters even when they go unanswered. Send the gifts even when they go unacknowledged. Let them know, by every means left to you, that your love has not changed and that you are waiting. Some of the most striking reunions I have witnessed came after years of patient waiting — the grandparent who kept praying, who kept sending the birthday card. The wait was long. The faithfulness was costly. And the reunion, when it came, was a resurrection.

A WORD TO CHURCHES

Honor your elderly. They are not a demographic to manage. They are the long memory of the faith, and they carry the stories the young families need.

Create intergenerational space. Let the old saints pray over the young families. Let the grandmothers hold the babies while the young mothers breathe. Let the grandfathers sit with the teenage boys and tell them what manhood has looked like across sixty years. Stop segregating by age group as though the generations have

To the grandparent who has read this far: your role is not finished. It may be entering its most important phase. The prayers you pray now may be the prayers that bring your grandchildren home twenty years from now. The stories you tell now may be the ones they remember when everything else has been forgotten. The love you give now may be the picture of God's love that surfaces at the moment of their greatest need. You are not retired from the work of formation. You are in the deep end of it. Stay there. Pray. Tell the stories. Be present. Let the long memory of your faith become the foundation of theirs.

You are living in a culture that worships youth and discards age, and the church has too often followed it, building its programs around the young while the elders sit in the pews with decades of tested faith and nobody asks them to testify. Resist the marginalization. You have what the young do not. You have lived proof. So tell the stories — not once, but many times, because the embedding requires repetition. Tell the story of how you came to faith. Tell the story of the hardest year of your life and how God carried you through it. Tell the story of the prayer that took twenty years to answer, the marriage that almost broke and was rebuilt, the child who wandered and came home. Your grandchild may not seem interested. Tell it anyway. Because ten years from now, or twenty, or thirty, in a moment of crisis you cannot foresee, the story will surface, and the memory of your faith will be the thing that holds when everything else gives way.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

When They Walk Away

There is a grief Christian parents carry in public because they have to, and that breaks them in private. It is the grief of a child who has walked away from the faith. I have sat with parents in it. I have held their hands across my office desk. I have watched a mother's face collapse when she said out loud, for the first time in months, that she does not know if her son believes anymore. I have watched fathers go quiet for a long time and then say they do not know what they are supposed to do with this. I approach no chapter of this book with more care than this one. The people reading it are sometimes bleeding, and platitudes are not what they need.

So I will name it plainly. Some of your children are going to walk away from the faith. Some of them already have. Some are walking away right now, inches at a time, and you can feel it but cannot yet say it. This has been true in every generation and is more pronounced in ours. It

NAME WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY LOOKING AT

I need to distinguish between a few things, because the distinctions change how you pray and how you respond. These children all feel the same to a parent. They are not the same.

There is the child in active rebellion, pushing against everything they were raised with, rejecting it loudly, often through choices you cannot endorse. This child is the easiest to identify and the hardest to answer, because the rebellion activates a parent's fear and anger at the same moment.

There is the child in honest questioning, who is not rebelling but thinking. They have met ideas that challenge what they were taught and they are working through them. They may skip church for a season. They may read authors you disagree with. They may say things that sound like unbelief but are the sound of a mind in the middle of examination. This child needs space, not pressure, and a parent who is not terrified — because a parent's terror tells the child the faith cannot survive being examined.

There is the child who has concluded, on the merits, that Christianity is not true. This one has arrived

There is the child wounded by the church. Something happened in a church context — a leader's failure, a community's hypocrisy, being hurt by people who claimed to represent God. Their departure is not from God. It is from the people who spoke for him. This child needs a parent who can separate the church's failures from God's character without defending the indefensible.

There is the child using unbelief as a permission slip. This one has not examined the faith and found it wanting. They have found it inconvenient and built a rationale for ignoring it. That is not an intellectual departure but a moral one, and the response must be different, because the root is different.

And there is the child who is unsure and ashamed — the most common and the least visible. This one has not walked away. They have drifted. They do not know what they believe and are afraid to say so, afraid of disappointing you. They perform faith while the faith evaporates behind the performance. This child needs a parent who creates room for honesty. Who says: you can tell me where you are, and I will not fall apart. The first pastoral work is to discern, as honestly as you can, which of these you are looking at. That discernment changes how you pray, how you speak, and how you wait.

IT IS A CHAPTER, NOT A VERDICT

A child walking away is not the end of the story. It is a

The whole New Testament is full of people who came to Christ long after their mothers stopped being able to make them. Augustine is one. Monica prayed for him for decades. Decades. He came home. Some of your children may take that long. You will have to do the hardest thing a parent of faith ever does, which is to entrust them to the Father across years of not knowing, without becoming either bitter or indulgent.

And hear this carefully: your child's walking away is not a verdict on your parenting. It may expose things that need confession. It may not. Many of the parents I have walked with in this grief were faithful. They did the work. They loved their children, prayed over them, made the hard calls. And the child still walked. Children are not products. They are persons, and persons have agency. A child made in the image of God will, at some point, make their own response to God. You cannot make it for them. You can only raise them in a home where response is invited. Whether they respond is, in the end, not within your control. That truth is painful. It is also freeing, if you will let it be.

WHAT KEEPS THE DOOR OPEN, AND WHAT SLAMS IT

I have seen things work and I have seen things destroy families, so let me go in both directions and be specific about each.

What works is the open door. Keep the relationship.

What destroys is the opposite. Making your love conditional on their belief. Withholding affection until they return. Weaponizing Scripture in every conversation. Grilling them about their spiritual life the moment they walk in. Shaming them in public. Triangulating other family members. Refusing to attend their wedding because they married someone you disapprove of. These are not Christian responses. They are the responses of a parent who has made the child's belief into an idol and is willing to harm the child for failing to feed it. It is common. It is never pastoral. It never leads back. It only hardens.

This will bother the stricter corners of the Christian parenting world, but I will say it. Tough love, in the way that phrase has been used over the last thirty years, has destroyed more relationships with prodigal children than it has restored. Look at the father in Luke 15. He did not chase his son and drag him home. He also did not cut him off in bitterness.



While he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him and kissed him.

That is the pattern. Let go. Watch. Run to them when they turn. It is not complicated in its structure. It is brutal in its execution, because the watching is what breaks you. The years of watching and not knowing — that is the suffering. God does not promise to remove it. He promises to carry you through it.

THE SINS THAT FIND GRIEVING PARENTS

There is a sin pattern among grieving Christian parents that I have watched destroy people, and I want to name it. It is the spiral of self-blame.

If I had done this differently. If I had not sent her to that school. If I had held on tighter. If I had let go sooner. If I had prayed more. If I had prayed less. If I had not been so strict, so lenient. You can replay every parental decision forever and never find the one you can hold up as the cause. The grief wants a cause because a cause is manageable, and mystery is not. Stay with the mystery anyway. Confess where you were actually wrong, specifically. Do not confess a general indictment against yourself, because a general indictment is not repentance. It is self-punishment. Repent of what you did. Entrust what is beyond that to God.

*The grief wants a cause because a
cause is manageable. Mystery is not.
Stay with the mystery anyway.*

WHAT IS ACTUALLY IN YOUR HAND

You need some practical counsel, so here it is. Do not go silent with your child. Keep the ordinary rhythms of relationship.

Text them about things that have nothing to do with faith. Ask about work. Ask about the dog. Send a photo of something that made you think of them. Tell them you love them, often, without strings. Invite them over, and when they come, feed them well, and let the conversation be about whatever they want. If they raise something spiritual, listen more than you speak. If they ask what you think, answer honestly, briefly, without escalating. Do not turn every encounter into a summit. Most of the time, just be their parent.

And pray. Pray specifically and often. Pray by name. Pray the passages that match the place they are in. Pray with your spouse. Pray with other parents in the same grief. Do not walk this alone — the enemy wants you isolated, because isolation is where parents fall apart. Find

The hope in this chapter is slow and heavy. It is that God is not finished. It is that you do not know what he is doing. It is that the child you are grieving may be being drawn, right now, in ways you cannot perceive, by a Father who loves them more than you do. Your role is not to secure their return. It is to be the kind of parent they would come home to, if they came home. Be that parent. That is what is in your hand. The rest is not.

Prepare yourself, too, for the possibility that you may not see the return in this life. It is hard to say, and I say it because it is true. Some children come home when you are old. Some come home after you are gone. Some come home in the last hour, in a way only God sees. Some, and we have to be honest, may not come home at all. This is the dark edge of the hope. You live in hope. You do not know the outcome. You do not control it. You entrust it to a Father who is both just and merciful, and whose mercy I would bet on, in the end, over my own reading of my child's trajectory any day. God is not a terrified parent. He is a steady one. Let him teach you his steadiness in the waiting.

TO THE PARENTS ON THE OTHER SIDE

I want to close with a word to parents whose children did come back. I have watched it happen after five years and after twenty — at thirty, at forty, at fifty. I have watched them come back quietly, without announcement, sometimes without telling their parents until months later. Through a crisis. Through a spouse. Through the birth of

The patterns of return are as varied as the patterns of departure, but a few threads run through nearly all of them. The child who comes back almost always says it was the parent's steady love they returned to. They do not say the parent's arguments convinced them. They say the love outlasted the rebellion. They say the door was always open. They say the prayers were felt, even when they pretended not to feel them.

They also often say the faith they returned to is not the faith they left. It is deeper. It is more honest. It has been tested by the departure and refined by the return. They do not come back to a childhood faith. They come back to an adult faith forged in the furnace of their own doubt and their own failure — and that faith is often stronger than the faith of the child who never left, because it was earned at greater cost.

If your child has come back, or is coming back, receive them. Do not make them perform gratitude for your faithfulness. Do not say you told them so. Do not require them to affirm every doctrine before you welcome them. Welcome them the way the father in Luke 15 welcomed his son. With a ring and a robe and a feast. With extravagant joy. With tears you have been holding for years. With the simple, devastating sentence: you were lost, and now you are found.

That is the gospel. That is the hope. That is what we have been building toward in every chapter of this book and every year of our children's lives. Not a guarantee. A hope — costly, earned, grief-tested, prayer-soaked — that God is the Father of our children, and that he is working

If you are reading this in the middle of the grief, hear one last thing. You are loved by Christ. He sees your grief. He is not angry with you for it. He is near to you in it. The children of God grieve with hope. You are not grieving wrong. You are grieving because you love. Keep loving. Keep praying. Keep the door open. And let the Father do what only a Father can do. He is working. Trust him.

CONCLUSION

The Long Obedience of Raising Believers

I will not restate the book. You read it; a summary at this point would insult your attention. What I owe you instead is a word about how to carry any of it into an ordinary Tuesday, because that is where parenting actually happens. Every book ever written on this subject is only as good as its ability to be lived out on a Tuesday when no one is watching.

So let me close the way the book began — in my own house, with my own children, where the principles I believe were tested against the life I was living.

A YEAR IN LUKE

One of my sons came to me a few years ago, at an age when I did not expect it, and asked if the two of us could read through a book of the Bible together. He picked Luke. We spent the better part of a year in it, chapter by chapter. Not every night. Some nights were short, some long, some

One of those nights he asked whether I thought Jesus actually rose from the dead. I told him I did. He asked why. We spent an hour there. I did not hand him a canned answer. I walked through what I actually believed — the historical evidence, the alternatives, why the resurrection has held for me under every alternative I have considered. He listened. He was quiet a long while. Then he said, I think I believe it too, Dad. Not a declaration. A small report, at the end of a year of reading together.

That conversation did not happen because I had a program. It happened because we had built the slow practice of reading and talking over months, because my life had given him reason to think the question was worth asking me, because I answered him honestly instead of defensively. That is formation. That is the thing I hope this book has moved you toward, in whatever season you are in with your children.

FROM THE VALLEY, NOT THE SUMMIT

I began writing during a week when one of my sons was struggling. I will not name the son or the nature of it; his story is his to tell. But the timing was not accidental. I started writing about the formation of children in the faith at the exact moment my own formation of my own child felt most fragile. I wrote about the household catechism while my household felt like it was running the wrong one. I wrote about answering questions while my son was asking ones I did not know how to answer.

That is the honest context of this book. It was not written from a summit of parental achievement. It was

Formation is proximity to a formed life, and that held: even as my son pulled away, he was near enough to watch what I did with my own fear. He saw me pray about it rather than rage about it. He saw me stay in the room rather than walk out of it. I do not know what he made of the watching. I know the watching was formation, whether it felt like it or not.

And then the hardest thing held — that a child's faith is, in the end, between him and God. I had to let go. Not of my parenting, not of my prayers, not of my presence. Of the outcome. I had to hand my son to God and say, he is Yours before he is mine, You love him more than I do, and I trust You with him even though I cannot see what You are doing. That surrender is the hardest act a Christian parent ever performs. It is also the final act of formation. It forms the parent.

*I am still in the story. I do not know
how it ends for my sons. They are still
being formed. They are still choosing.
And I am still in the room.*

I think about my mother. She raised me without a father, without faith, without a model for any of the things I have written about here. She did not form me in the Christian faith, because she did not have it. But she formed me in something the faith would later fill. She formed me in honesty. She told me the truth about our situation. She did not pretend we were fine when we were not. She worked two jobs and cried in the kitchen when she thought I was asleep and got up the next morning and did it again. What I absorbed from her was not theology. It was the refusal to quit.

When I came to faith in college, everything she had formed in me found its home. The honesty became confession. The endurance became perseverance. The refusal to quit became faithfulness. She did not give me the faith. But she gave me the soil. And the soil received the seed, and the seed grew.

That is what you are doing. You are preparing soil. You are pulling weeds, watering ground. The seed is not yours to manufacture; the seed belongs to God. Your work is to make the ground as ready as you can, with the tools you have, in the time you are given. And the time is shorter than you think. Your children will be grown before you are ready for it. Use the years. Not perfectly. Faithfully.

This is the long obedience of raising believers. It is not dramatic. It does not make for good social media. It is slow and hidden and mostly unnoticed, done in kitchens and cars and at bedsides, over decades, by parents who decided quietly that they would rather be faithful than impressive. It is the work of being near your children, for a



*I will be a Father to the fatherless, and a husband to
the widow. He sets the lonely in families.*

— PSALM 68:5-6

So go. Into the kitchen. Into the car. Into the bedroom where the child is waiting for the blessing. Go with the confidence that the small thing you do tonight is the thing God will use — not because it is impressive, but because it is faithful. And faithfulness, in the economy of God, is the only currency that never loses its value. Go. Raise them.

